

RICHARD CAREW, THE ORDINARY, THE
ORDINALIA, AND THE ORDINARY ACTOR
on the Medieval Cornish Stage

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Richard Carew's description of the medieval Cornish 'Guary miracle' play has generally been treated with considerable scepticism. Did actors of Cornish plays customarily act their parts without memorizing their lines? Did a figure known as the 'Ordinary' follow behind them, whispering their lines in their ears so that they might in turn repeat them aloud to the audience? E.K. Chambers questioned whether Carew's report 'may be trusted', and thought that even if so, 'probably this was exceptional'.¹ Brian Murdoch sums up what has been the majority consensus: 'Although cited in most secondary studies, Carew's comments must be treated with caution and their specific relevance is questionable'.² The editors of the Cornwall instalment of the *Records of Early English Drama* likewise stress the 'problematic' nature of 'Carew's assertion that the Cornish actors did not memorise their parts but repeated them after an on-stage prompter'. Even if authentic rather than apocryphal, they agree with Chambers: Carew's commentary 'probably should not be construed as having widespread application to all of the Cornish drama'.³

There has always been a dissenting minority to this sceptical consensus. Glynne Wickham, for instance, regards Carew's description as relatively trustworthy: 'his function extended beyond that of the modern prompter to that of the *repetiteur* in opera who cues in all the singers by repeating the entire text loudly enough to be audible to them, but not to the audience'.⁴ More recently, the sceptical consensus has been challenged in a series of articles by Philip Butterworth. Instead of regarding Carew's account as eccentric, Butterworth would have us regard it as reliable evidence of a widespread 'medieval staging convention' that may have been employed well beyond the borders of Cornwall.⁵ This scholarly program has had some effect in moving the consensus more in the direction of Wickham's *repetiteur* than the sceptical views of Murdoch and the REED editors. Gloria J. Betcher thus rejects 'the suspicion among drama scholars, who ... have at times found the description farfetched'.⁶ By the same token, Peter Holland is persuaded that in 'certain non-professional forms of theatre' such as the Cornish plays that are the subject of Carew's anecdote, 'the

actors do not need to learn their lines at all and instead [they were enabled to] rely on a continuous prompt'.⁷ Some historians of the theatre now regard it as a settled fact that, not just in Cornwall, but in England too, medieval 'actors were literally "conducted" as to when to speak' by an onstage prompter.⁸

Carew, however, provides the only witness of this theatrical practice. Nowhere else do we hear of a director-cum-prompter who feeds an actor lines that he has not learned beforehand. Much therefore depends upon the credibility of this anecdote. Although most scholars are probably familiar with Carew's anecdote by now, nevertheless we should have the text before us as we begin our examination:

The Guary miracle, in English, a miracle-play, is a kinde of Enterlude, compiled in *Cornish* out of some scripture history, with that grossenes, which accompanied the Romanes *vetus Comedia*. For representing it, they raise an earthen Amphitheatre, in some open field, hauing the Diameter of his enclosed playne some 40. or 50. foot. The Country people flock from all sides, many miles off, to hear and see it: for they haue therein, deuils and deuices, to delight as well the eye as the eare: the players conne not their parts without booke, but are prompted by one called the Ordinary, who followeth at their back with the booke in his hand, and telleth them softly what they must pronounce aloud. Which maner once gaue occasion to a pleasant conceyted gentleman, of practising a mery pranke: for he vndertaking (perhaps of set purpose) an Actors roome, was accordingly lessoned (before-hand) by the Ordinary, that he must say after him. His turne came: quoth the Ordinary, Go forth man and shew thy selfe. The gentleman steps out vpon the stage, and like a bad Clarke in scripture matters, cleauing more to the letter then the sense, pronounced those words aloud. Oh (sayes the fellowe softly in his eare) you marre all the play. And with this his passion, the Actor makes the audience in like sort acquainted. Hereon the prompter falles to flat rayling & cursing in the bitterest termes he could deuise: which the Gentleman with a set gesture and countenance still soberly related, vntill the Ordinary, driuen at last into a madde rage, was faine to giue ouer all. Which trousse though it brake off the Enterlude, yet defrauded not the beholders, but dismissed them with a great deale more sport and laughter, then 20. such Guaries could haue afforded.⁹

Those who find this account of the Cornish 'Guary' convincing and unproblematic take issue with those 'writers who have doubted the accuracy of Carew's observation'. The anecdote must be substantially accurate, it is argued, not the least because Carew himself 'is concerned that the reader should be able to depend upon his observations'.¹⁰ It must surely be a record made from observation. As Betcher puts it, 'Carew renders what appears to be an eye-witness account of the performance of a religious 'enterlude''.¹¹

Whatever else it is, Carew's account is anecdotal evidence. 'Anecdotal' does not necessarily mean 'untrue;' it simply means that such an anecdote in itself cannot be thought of as a typical example of anything without further corroboration. At the very least, such anecdotes require careful examination. Before we use Carew's narrative to establish the existence of something called a 'medieval staging convention', we should at least examine it carefully to consider its reliability as evidence. Has Carew personally witnessed the event he described? If so, has he reported it convincingly? If not, can we identify the source and reliability of the anecdote? What evidence can be brought to bear to corroborate the anecdotal evidence?

The study of Carew's anecdote is not a simple and straightforward enquiry. Even if one thinks that Carew's anecdote is plainly wrong, we should try to understand why Carew found it credible. It is not impossible that, even if Carew badly understood his source of information, nevertheless the anecdote may yet contain some valuable information about the performance of medieval theatre in Cornwall and elsewhere.

A thorough consideration of this important passage, I believe, must therefore consider Carew himself, particularly his methods as a researcher and writer, his knowledge of the Cornish language, and his familiarity with theatrical performance, whether Cornish or English. Secondly, we need to investigate the meaning and implications of the title that Carew gives his prompter: the Ordinary. Then we should consider the *Ordinalia* and other surviving Cornish dramatic texts to see whether they offer evidence to confirm Carew's anecdote, or instead provide evidence that ordinary actors routinely memorised their lines. Following this, we shall consider the evidence that has so far been offered to establish the existence of a theatrical convention of prompting in full view of the audience. Finally, I shall offer an alternative hypothesis for understanding how we might understand Carew's Ordinary and his method of prompting.

2. 'An eyewitness account'

Those who champion the anecdote as a factual account of a 'medieval staging convention' are understandably anxious to establish Carew's description as an eyewitness account. Carew, moreover, was a principled and honest scholar. 'A reporter', he asserts, 'must auerre no falsehood, nor conceale any truth' (67^r). One thus cannot seriously doubt that he believed that Cornish 'Guary miracles' were routinely performed by means of 'the Ordinary who followeth at their [the actors'] back with the booke in his hand, and telleth them softly what they must pronounce aloud'. Obviously, if he had actually witnessed the episode he describes, then the statement would have undeniable evidential authority. On the other hand, if Carew has not personally witnessed this event, the reliability of the episode must necessarily depend upon both the reliability of the source from which he takes his information and from his own understanding of what he has heard from that source.

Carew often relies upon personal observation or research in his account of Cornwall. Particularly in the Second Book of his *Survey*, where first-person narration serves as the default mode, his narrative takes the form of a disciplined, personal survey: 'In my particular view, I wil make easie iournies from place to place, as they lye in my way, taking the Hundreds for my guydes, vntill I haue accomplished this wearisome voyage' (98^r). He passes from town to town, examines notable features of the landscape, calls at the houses of gentlemen and nobility (whose lineages he customarily reports), places historical events in their context, recounts colourful or peculiar customs, and notes remarkable people. He sees, investigates, inquires, takes notes,¹² and is always eager to record the source of his information, whether his own observation or the reports of other trusted informants. At Tintagel, for instance, he tells us,

at the top, two, or three terrifying steps, giue you entrance to the hill, which supplieth pasture for sheepe, and conyes: Vpon the same, I saw, a decayed Chappell, a faire spring of water, a Caue, reaching once, by my guides report, some farre way vnder ground, and (which you will perhaps suspect of vntruth) an Hermites graue, hewen out of the rocke, and seruing each bodies proportion for a buriall. fol.120^v

His seeing eye constantly validates the information he includes in this Second Book: 'Thither I rode, to take view of an antiquitie, called, The other halfe stone; which I found to be thus ...' (128^v). Again and again,

the reader sees as Carew sees: 'I saw ...'; 'I found ...'; 'are to be seene ...'; 'by this time we approach ...'; 'Descending from Truro ... you are overlooked ...'; 'I observe ...'¹³

The Ordinary makes his appearance, however, not in the Second Book of the *Survey* but the First. Here scholarly research serves as the default mode, and the eye characteristically falls on books and records rather than landscapes. He frequently cites acts of Parliament, heraldic achievements, pedigrees, historians classical and modern (e.g. Ptolemy, Strabo, Artemidorus, Justus Lipsius, William Camden), and poets, writers, and chronicles. At one point, he inserts a document setting forth 'the *Cornish* Knights fees and acres, which I receyued from my learned and religious kinseman Master *Robert Moyle*'. A Latin document dating from 1401–1402, it takes up 28 pages of *The Survey* (39^r–52^v). In estimating the Cornish military forces, for instance, he tells us that 'I haue gathered' the information 'partly out of our certificate made to the Lords 1599, partly by information from the Sargeant maior, & partly through mine owne knowledge' (83^v). As these examples show, he characteristically strives to credit the sources of his information, whether documentary or personal.

Personal anecdotes sometimes also appear in the First Book, as when he is discussing the county's 'venimous Wormes'. The passage deserves to be considered in full because it offers a fruitful comparison with Carew's 'Guary miracle' anecdote.

Touching venimous Wormes, *Cornwall* can plead no such Charter of natures exemption, as *Ireland*. The countrey people retaine a conceite, that the *Snakes*, by their breathing about a hazell wand, doe make a stone ring of blew colour, in which there appeareth the yellow figure of a *Snake*, & that beasts which are stung, being giuen to drink of the water wherein this stone hath bene soked, will therethrough recouer. There was such a one bestowed on me, and the giuer auowed to haue seene a part of the stick sticking in it: but *Penes authorem sit fides*.

This mention of *Snakes*, called to my remembrance, how not long since, a merry *Cornish* Gentleman tryed
 Martin that old fable to be no fable, which sheweth the
 Trewy dangerous entertayning of such a ghest [*exploit*]. For
 nard he hauing gotten one of that kind, and broken out his
 teeth (wherein consisteth his venome) used to carrie
 him about in his bosome, to set him to his mouth, to
 make him licke his spittle, & when he came among Gentlewomen,

would cast him out suddenly, to put them in feare: but in the end, their vaine dread proued safer then his foole-hardinesse: for as he once walked alone, and was kissing this gentle playfellow, the *Snake* in good earnest, with a stumpe, either newly growne vp, or not fully pulled out, bit him fast by the tongue, which therewith began so to rankle and swell, that by the time hee had knocked this foule player on the head, & was come to his place of abode, his mouth was scarce able to contayne it. Fayne was he therefore to shew his mishap, and by gestures to craue ayd in earnest of the Gentlewomen, whom hee had aforetime often scared in sport.

fols 21^v–22^r

Like the ‘Guary miracle’, passage, Carew thus views Cornish herpetology from two ‘conceites’: that of the ‘countrey people’ on the one hand, and that of a ‘merry *Cornish* Gentleman’ on the other.

Let us begin with the ‘countrey people’. By ‘countrey people’, Carew means rural farmers, fishers, and tin-miners, many of them Cornish-speakers, whom he plainly regards as his social and intellectual inferiors.¹⁴ Though good and worthy in general, he often finds them backward and resistant to improvements offered by their fellow English subjects. Like ‘the Welsh, their auncient countrimen’, they foster ‘a fresh memorie of their expulsion long agoe by the English’, and then ‘they second the same with a bitter repining at their fellowship’ (67^r). Like Carew’s herpetological informant, the ‘countrey people’ were prone to ‘many strange ‘conceits’ — that a faggot thrown into Dozmary Pool was once ‘taken vp at Foy hauen, 6. miles distant’ (122^r), for instance, or a ‘foolish conceit’ that a cross thrown into a well on Palm Sunday had the power to fortell life and death: ‘if it swamme, the party should outliue that yeere; if it sunk, a short ensuing death was boded’ (144^v). Nevertheless, their conceits are sometimes based upon an ancient, natural wisdom that Carew warmly admires. Their wisdom can often make fools of the gentry, who underestimate them. When ‘some Gentlemen’ thus doubted a ‘conceit’ long held by ‘the Countrie people’ that oysters ‘weare out of kind’ (*cease breeding*) in summertime and ought not to be taken in that season, they ‘began to eat them at all seasons’. They soon discovered, however, that ‘to eat them at all seasons’ soon produced ‘a scarcitie’ (30^v). In his references to the ‘Countrey people’, Carew finds himself negotiating a fine line between a tolerant amusement at their ‘foolish conceits’ and a thoughtful appreciation of their ancient knowledge of life in Cornwall.

Carew presents his informant's herpetological 'conceit' as one of the more questionable ones. While it derives from ancient beliefs still 'retained' by the 'countrey people', it clearly conflicts with Carew's own sense of educated, intellectual superiority. When one of these people gives him such a token — a blue and yellow stone ring — as a snakebite remedy, he accepts it with tolerant amusement and dismisses it with a Latin tag, an educated man's remedy against foolish¹⁵ conceits: *Penes authorem sit fides* ('If one can believe the author').¹⁶ In this way, he exercises his reporter's mandate. He must report this folk belief because he must not 'conceale any truth;' but he must also reject that belief because he must 'auerre no falsehood'.

For these reasons, Carew is anxious to document the sources of this passage to make it the more credible to his reader. A specific person — one of the 'countrey people' — gave him the token and explained to him its significance. Carew thus held in his hand an example of the blue stone ring with the yellow figure of a snake and so he can claim to report what he has actually seen. He likewise offers convincing details about the discomfiture of the 'merry Cornish gentleman', and even if he did not personally witness his snakebitten tongue, he provides specific details that only someone close to the episode would know (i.e., he breaks out the snake's teeth, carries the reptile in his bosom, terrifies ladies by letting it lick his spittle, and tells us specifically that he was bitten on the tongue that has swollen so large that his mouth could scarcely contain it). Finally, he identifies the hapless man as Martin Trewynard, a Cornish gentleman who has left traces of lawsuits over property disputes and inheritance in Stannary Courts and Chancery records.¹⁷ In both cases, the details and documentation in these episodes put Carew very convincingly at the source of the information he passes on.

Elsewhere, he frequently accepts second-hand information into his *Survey*. Often he cites his sources by name, if they are reputable gentlemen or, better still, kinsmen: 'This I learned by the report of Sir *Peter Carew*, the elder of that name' (102^v). He never identifies those of the lower classes by name, even if he may accept their testimony as valid. He is content, for instance, to report the practice of 'bowssening' at St Nunnes well to unidentified witnesses: 'I wil, (if you please) deliuer you the practise, as I receyued it from the beholders' (123^r). Often, he identifies his informants still more obliquely, particularly if they are common workmen: 'I haue receiued credible information, that some three yeeres sithence, certaine hedgers deuiding a crosse on the sea side hereabouts, chanced, in

their digging, vpon a great chest of stone' (136^v-137^r). The rural informant who presents Carew with a blue stone ring and a story about snakes is perhaps still more distanced. Carew clearly does not believe that the information he receives is credible, but it serves very well to illustrate the characteristically foolish 'conceits' of the 'countrey people'. He takes his self-professed role as 'a reporter' seriously, and he therefore usually seeks to make his sources, and their reliability, clear.

By contrast, Carew never claims to have personally witnessed a 'Guary miracle'. The 'Countrey people' may well 'flock from all sides, many miles off, to heare & see it', but Carew does not. Had he actually seen such a performance, one might expect him to tell us specific details about what he saw performed in such an 'earthen Amphitheatre:' a play of the Creation, perhaps, or of a particular saint, or of Arthur. Instead, we get 'some scripture history', and he further places the amphitheatre not in a particular site but 'in some open field', a description that further distances him from actual observation. The country people, he tells us, come to the Guary not for its scriptural history, but because such plays appeal to their characteristically strange and foolish conceits: 'they haue therein, deuils and deuices, to delight as well the eye as the eare'. But what devils and devices has he personally seen and heard? As he does in rejecting the snakebite remedy, he dismisses the appeal of the Guary with a university-educated man's reproach: they contain 'that grossenes, which accompanied the Romanes *vetus Comedia*'.¹⁸

All this suggests considerable distance between Carew and the performance of a Guary. This is no eyewitness account peppered with personally observed details as he does elsewhere in order to make it abundantly clear what he has personally seen and heard. Here he seems to be relying upon a report or reports that he has heard about from someone somewhere. No witness is identified, neither country person nor merry Cornish gentleman. The source or sources of the anecdote plainly are at some distance from Carew's telling.

The absence of sources in the 'Guary miracle' passage should therefore alert us to some distance between Carew's knowledge and the sources of that knowledge. This distance from his sources of information likewise characterises those details that might seem very specific: he tells us that the 'earthen amphitheatre' he describes has 'the diameter of his enclosed playne some 40. or 50. foot'. Although this is considerably smaller than those *plains-an-guary* still extant at St Just and Perranzuloe, such 'playing places may not have been uniform in size', as Sally L. Joyce and Evelyn S.

Newlyn rightly point out.¹⁹ But Carew has himself not measured such a round, nor does he see any throughout his itinerary through the Hundreds of Cornwall. Passing through Perranzabuloe, he describes the ‘deluge’ of sand that ‘draue the Inhabitants to remooue their Church’, but he makes no mention of the Piran Round, which lay just a short distance from the church (148^r). He may not have passed through the village of St Just, with its *Plain-an-Gwarry* at the centre of the village, but he does mention the College of Priests in the neighbouring parish of St Buriens (159^f). Carew certainly believes what he is saying to be true, but his belief is not anchored to either his own observation, the report of a trustworthy witness, or to a document of some kind. Moreover, because he plainly regards the ‘Guary miracle’ as a pastime designed particularly for the country people and designed for their uneducated tastes, it is not likely the sort of event that he would investigate too closely himself.

The latter half of Carew’s description of the ‘Guary miracle’ features a ‘pleasant conceyted gentleman’ rather than one of the ‘countrey people’. Its protagonist thus belongs to Carew’s own ‘degree’, the Cornish gentry, and he describes him in much the same way as does the ‘merry *Cornish Gentleman*’ who carried a snake about in his bosom to frighten the ‘gentlewomen’ he chanced upon. Both ‘gentlemen’, moreover, are engaged in activities more characteristic of the ‘countrey people’ than their own station, and both are described as motivated by a conceit. The merry gentleman tries out the ‘old fable’ about snakebite that Carew has just dismissed as a ‘conceyt’ of the ‘countrey people’, while the ‘pleasant conceyted gentleman’ pretends to misunderstand the directions of the Ordinary, who is prompting the actors in a play designed for the ‘Country people’. The merry gentleman gets his comeuppance when the snake seems to have regrown a fang, while the pleasantly ‘conceyted’ gentleman triumphantly carries off his ‘pranke’ over the hapless Ordinary. Perhaps these differences in outcomes also reflect class distinctions. Carew depicts the merry gentleman as *déclassé*; his ungentlemanly prank lowers him in status and makes him appear intellectually foolish. His comeuppance thus delivers a kind of rough moral justice: the gentleman becomes a country dunce. In the context of the Guary, however, the trickster gentleman emerges triumphant because he asserts his social and intellectual superiority over the Ordinary. He turns the tables on his would-be director and subjects the Ordinary to his own direction. By doing so, he also mocks the ‘grossenes’ of the play. By successfully imitating the

foolishness of a country dunce, he asserts both the social and intellectual superiority of a gentleman.

These two anecdotes involving witty young gentlemen differ in one crucial respect: the *Survey* documents the source of the snake-bite episode, but not that of the vexed Guary director. Carew regularly names the gentry he mentions, but not the country people, even when he judges that the latter provide trustworthy information.²⁰ His herpetological passage thus conforms to this rule: on the one hand Carew credits his information about the country people's 'conceite' merely to 'such a one'. On the other hand, he identifies the foolish snakebite victim as Martin Trewynard. By contrast, Carew does not indicate any source whatsoever of the vexed Ordinary anecdote. He does not even refer to 'a Gentleman, dwelling not farre off' or assure us that 'I haue receiued credible information' as he often does when he gives us information not attributed to a named informant (136^v). The 'merry Cornish gentleman' remains nameless despite the author's apparent approval of his witty prank. Nor does he tell us from whom he learned that 'one called the Ordinary' prompted the actors. Once again, this lack of attribution, or at least assurance, suggests some distance between Carew's telling and the information itself. Nor does it help that the anecdote resembles one of those jokes about bad actors misunderstanding the conventions of theatrical performance, as when Flute, the 'rude mechanical', speaks 'all [his] part at once, cues and all' in Shakespeare's *Midsummer Night's Dream*.²¹

3. Carew and the Cornish language

Carew was born in the far east of Cornwall just across the Tamar from Devon, an area that had much more in common with English-speaking Devon, linguistically and culturally, than with the Cornish-speaking west of the County. English had become dominant in Carew's part of Cornwall by the twelfth century, and in Carew's era, even the memory of the Cornish language had long been extinguished there.²² One will not be surprised to learn, then, that that Carew's knowledge of Cornish was slight and that he would have difficulty in either carrying on a conversation or understanding a performance of a play in that language.²³ Nevertheless, Carew was interested in the Cornish language, and if we are to understand what Carew knew of the 'Guary miracle', we must pay attention to the extent of his knowledge of the language. We need to know whether he could converse in or understand Cornish speech, whether he could read and translate Cornish texts, and how he amassed the Cornish-language

information that he displays in the *Survey*. Then, perhaps, we will be in a better position to assess his description of the Cornish play and its mode of performance.

The *Survey* frequently records the cultural differences between the writer and his Western countrymen. In a particularly telling passage, Carew tells us that 'in times not past the remembrance of some yet liuing', Cornish farmers 'rubbed forth their estate in the poorest plight'. However, he notes with satisfaction, now that

the Cornish husbandman conformeth himself with a better supplied ciuilitie to the Easterne patterne, which hath directed him a more thriuing forme of husbandrie; and our halcion dayes of peace enabled him to applie the lesson: so as, his fine once ouercome, he can maintaine himselfe & his familie in a competent decencie to their calling, and findeth monie to bestow weekly at the markets, for his prouisions of necessitie and pleasure: for his quarterlie rent serueth rather as a token of subiection to his Land-lord, then any grieuous exaction on his tenement. fol. 66^v

In these observations 'Eastern' does not refer to the Eastern Cornish but to the English, and 'our halcion days of peace' refers to the end of the last Cornish rebellion. Political and cultural domination, from Carew's point of view, has done the Cornish much good.

Carew's attitude toward the Cornish language was necessarily connected closely with the rebellion of 1549, which in large part was driven by Tudor attempts to impose the Edwardian Book of Common Prayer upon the Cornish-speaking population who were still largely Catholic. The rebels, for instance, refused the new Prayer Book not only because it replaced the Latin mass, but also because the new service was in English: 'we the Cornyshe men (whereof certen of us understande no Englysh) utterly refuse thys new Englysh'.²⁴ The rebellion thus made the Cornish language politically suspect in that it suggested that speakers may well be allies of the Catholic powers on the Continent and ready to conspire with them against the Tudor regime. The suppression of the rebellion, in turn, made Cornish into 'a language of the Commons'. The gentry, like the Carews, had little incentive to learn the language and considerable reason not to learn it.²⁵

The Carews were heavily invested in putting down the rebellion; Somerset dispatched both Sir Peter Carew and Gawen Carew to deal with the rebels.²⁶ It is not surprising, therefore, that the writer's sympathies lay

solidly upon the establishment side and that he often views the Cornish as potentially rebellious, disloyal, and dishonourable. As he travels through the Hundreds, Carew finds much to remind him of the 1549 insurrection. The rebellion, he tells us, began at Heston, where 'one *Kilter*, and others his associats ... imbrued their wicked hands in the guiltles blood of one *M. Body*, as he sate in Commission ... for matters of reformation in religion' (98^r). Later, he recalls Sir Richard Grenville the elder being lured out of Trematon Castle by the promise of a parley by 'those rakehels, not knowing what honestie, and farre lesse, how much the word of a souldier imported'. They treacherously 'laid hold on his aged vnweyldie body, and threatned to leaue it liuelesse' unless the defenders capitulated. 'Prosecuting their first treacherie against the prince, with suteable actions towards his subiects, they seized on the Castle, and exercised the vttermost of their barbarous crueltie (deth excepted) on the surprised prisoners'. The women were stripped to their smocks, their fingers broken to 'plucke away their rings' (111^v–112^r). At St Michael's Mount, the 'slender resistance' of the castle, 'together with the womens dismay, & decrease of victuals, forced a surrender to those Rakehels mercy, who, nothing guilty of that effeminate vertue, spoyled their goods, imprisoned their bodies', and only by 'Gods gracious prouidence' were they 'restrayned from murdering the principall persons' (155^v). The melodramatic hyperbole of these passages says much about his English sympathies and his fear of the rebellious nature of the Cornish underclass when motivated by what we might today think of as 'nationalist' passions.

From Carew's point of view, resentment of the English is one of the defining characteristics of the 'old countrey people' he meets. 'Some of the Westernne people doe yet still retaine ... a fresh memorie of their expulsion long agoe by the English, they second the same with a bitter repining at their fellowship: and this the worst sort expresse, in combining against, and working them all the shrewd turnes which with hope of impunitie they can deuise'. Some, however, have become less overtly restive: 'to their gentlemen they carrie a verie dutifull regard, as enured in their obeysance from their ancestors, and holding them as *Royetelets* ['little kings'], because they know no greater' (66^v–67^r).

When travelling in the 'vttermost skirts of the shire' where Cornish was still spoken but 'the English speach doth still encroche vpon it', Carew was not often treated as a little king by the 'Westernne people', and he seems to have experienced his share of 'shrewd turnes' worked upon him. He grumbles that while 'most of the Inhabitants can no word of *Cornish*', and

‘few are ignorant of the English’, nevertheless ‘some so affect their owne [Cornish language], as to a stranger they will not speake it [English]’. He thus complains as one accustomed to addressing Cornish speakers in English and who is always surprised when they insist on responding in Cornish. ‘If meeting them by chance, you inquire the way or any such matter, your answer shalbe *Meea nauidua cowz asawznek*, I can speake no Saxonage’ (56^r).²⁷ Except for two very brief ‘prophetically rime[s]’, this is the most extensive illustration of the Cornish language that Carew includes in his text; it is, moreover, the only one that derives directly from his own reported experience.²⁸ Although he refers to the Lord’s Prayer, the Apostles Creed, and the Ten Commandments, which ‘haue beene vsed in *Cornish* beyond all remembrance’ (56^r),²⁹ he does not quote a single line from them. Beyond these, he never mentions a single specific text of a work in Cornish anywhere in the *Survey*. Indeed when takes up ‘Learned men’ in the *Survey*, he can only think of ‘few as yet are onely come to my notice’, and all of them wrote either in Latin or English (59^r). One wonders how much Cornish he could possibly have learned if he does not read Cornish texts and he routinely expects to converse with Cornish speakers in English because he thinks that they all know English anyway, even if some refuse to speak it.

Despite its attempt to examine the Cornish language from a scholarly perspective, Carew’s discussion is disappointingly slight and sometimes mistaken. Carew the scholar thus begins by noting its ‘affinity with the *Welsh*, which seem only dialects of one another’ and thinks that it must also be ‘deriued from, or at least had some acquayntance with the Greeke’. The only grammatical feature of the language that he mentions is that Cornish speakers ‘place the adiectiue after the substantiue’. He then tells us the Cornish names for numbers from one to 10,000. The language he thinks has only two or three oaths, but ‘this want is releued with a flood of most bitter curses, and spitefull nick-names’. He concludes his survey with a short list of useful nouns — ‘a sister, they call *whoore*; a whoore, *whorra*: a priest, *coggaz*’ — conventional expressions — *Relauta* (‘by my troth’); *Durdatha why* (‘Good morrow to you’); *Ternestatha* (‘Good night’); *Fatlugan a why?* (‘How do you?’); *Da durdalathawhy* (‘Wel I thanke you’); *Betha why lawanneck* (‘Be you mery’); *Benetugana* (‘Farewell’) — and curses: *Molla tuenda laaz* (‘ten thousand mischiefs in thy guts’); *Mille vengeance warnathy* (‘a thousand vengeancees take thee’) (55^v–56^r). Even if his intention here is to give only a brief snapshot of the language, this is by any measure a disappointing and inadequate one.

All together, the evidence that Carew himself offers us suggests at best a very elementary grasp of Cornish. One can overlook his suggestion that 'the Cornish tongue was deriued from, or at least had some acquayntance with the Greeks' — it is very much an educated man's speculation — and he does rightly connect Cornish with Welsh as 'deduced' from a common source and differing only in dialect. But he makes no mention of Armoric, which also is 'deduced' from the same source and is even arguably more closely related to Cornish, and he should have known that; he often mentions Cornwall's close relationships with Brittany (e.g. 96^r–7^v). Moreover, he is often incorrect in his translations of Cornish words and phrases, sometimes dramatically so. He tells us that there is no Cornish word for 'tye', but there is: *kilmy* is quite a common word, both in Carew's time and earlier.³⁰ Sometimes his translations miss the mark quite dramatically: *Pol* is 'a pool or pit', not 'a top'; *Godolghan* does not mean 'white eagle' but 'a little tump or mound'; *Bokelly* does not mean 'goat' but 'a grove dwelling'; *meea navidna* [*sic* for *My ny-vynnaf*] does not mean 'I cannot' but 'I will not', a crucial difference.³¹

Even in a snapshot, it seems odd that the only grammatical feature of Cornish that he chooses to mention is that adjectives follow nouns. This syntactical feature, of course, Cornish has in common with other modern European languages which he did know, such as Spanish, Italian, and French. Would it not have been more informative to tell us about some of the more remarkable features of the Cornish language, for instance that in Cornish, unlike all these other languages, every verb may be conjugated in three different modes and that there are five tenses?³² Even among his illustrative Cornish expressions, we find *vengeance*, an anglicised Cornish word, instead of the more common Cornish word, *dial*. If he really does mean the plural, *vengeances*, then this anglicised word further lacks a Cornish plural ending. This superficiality is all very odd for a writer who elsewhere writes so eloquently about languages in *The Excellency of the English Tongue*.³³

But let us not be too hasty in our judgment. As Philip Butterworth rightly points out, 'Carew understood languages other than English', and that he was proud enough of his linguistic accomplishments to have recorded on his tombstone the boast that he was fluent in Greek, Italian, German, French, and Spanish.³⁴ Indeed, Carew taught himself these languages, and he published translations of Italian and French works.³⁵ He was also an Oxford scholar, and necessarily knew Latin. One cannot push this point too far, however. Because he taught himself all these

languages, it does not necessarily follow that he also knew Cornish. As John Chynoweth points out, 'it was from books that he had learned the five foreign languages he had taught himself, and there were no such books in Cornish'.³⁶ He could certainly read and translate from these languages, but since he was self-taught and never travelled outside England, he probably never learned to speak them. Nevertheless, Carew was certainly linguistically apt, a polyglot even, and he took what must be considered a scholarly interest in the ancient language of his County, even if he did not necessarily speak it, write it, or translate from it.

To understand the nature of Carew's interest in the Cornish language, it may be useful to notice that he singles out two men for their knowledge of Cornish: John Kennell, LLD and Thomas Williams. 'The principall loue and knowledge of this language', Carew tells us, 'liued in *Doctor Kennall* the Ciuilian, and with him lyeth buried' (55^r-56^r). Kennall (1511-1592) was Canon of Christ Church, Oxford (1559-1592), and Archdeacon of Oxford (1561-1592). When Carew entered Christ Church in 1566, Kennall was Vice-Chancellor of Oxford University, and in that capacity, he presided over the lavish entertainments for Queen Elizabeth in August and September.³⁷ Nowhere in the *Survey* does he credit Kennall as the source of any information whatsoever about Cornwall or the Cornish language.³⁸ To judge from the elegiac nature of his references to the Vice-Chancellor, Carew had not yet written his passages on the Cornish language before Kennall's death in 1592.³⁹ It is therefore not likely that he played any role in supplying information for Carew's project. Kennall seems to have served Carew mainly as an inspirational figure, a Cornishman who had achieved high office at Oxford.

If Kennall serves Carew as a Cornish scholar's *beau idéal*, 'master *Thomas Williams*' was a fellow student at Oxford, 'a friend of mine'. Carew tells us that he 'discoursed' with him about the Cornish language, and that Williams had been the one who had convinced him that Cornish was 'deriued from' Greek. Williams, of course, is a fairly common name, but Carew's friend can nevertheless be identified with considerable probability. Born about 1545 or 1546, Williams, a Welshman (hence his name is more properly given as Wiliems), would have been Carew's elder by nine or ten years. If he was the 'Thomas Williams' who took his BA in 1567 and MA in 1573, he would have arrived at Oxford a few years before Carew.⁴⁰ Despite their 'discourse', however, Wiliems was not primarily interested in the Cornish language. According to William David Williams, he was an 'ardent student of Welsh literature and a diligent collector and copyist of

old manuscripts'. More to the point for our purposes, Wiliems began the great work of his life while at Oxford, his *Thesaurus linguae Latinae et Cambrobritannicae*, a Latin-Welsh dictionary.⁴¹

These references to Kennall and Wiliems suggest that Carew's interest in the Cornish language is associated with his years at Oxford. The reference to Wiliems, moreover, tells us much about Carew's knowledge of Cornish and his primary interest in it. Wiliems was a Welshman whose interest in Cornish was entirely etymological. This is perfectly clear in the material that Carew takes from his 'discourse' with his friend and elder scholar. He introduces Wiliems to the *Survey* in the context of observing that Cornish and Welsh are 'deduced from the same source, and differeth onely in the dialect'. He then mentions that Wiliems had convinced him that 'the *Cornish* tongue was deriued from, or at least had some acquayntance with the Greeke', mentions 'diverse reasons which hee produced to proue the same', and then supplies an illustrative list of ten words each of Greek, Cornish and English — only a few of many, he assures us — to prove the point (55^f–v). Carew's inclusion of this material tells us not only that he admired his friend, but that he had high regard as well for his friend's lexicographical approach to language.

We should not be surprised, then, to notice that Carew's own account of the Cornish language is entirely lexicographical. He delights in the Cornish names of things: numbers, sisters, whores, priests, partridges, mares. Even when he mentions verbs, they are presented nominally, as when he mentions the lack of a Cornish 'word for Tye'. In much the same way, he offers Cornish phrases as if they were dictionary entries, whether social expressions ('*Durdatha why* is Good morrow to you'), or 'bitter curses, and spitefull nick-names': '*Molla tuenda laaz*, ten thousand mischiefs in thy guts' (55^v–56^f). In this respect, Carew discusses what we might call 'Cornishisms' in exactly the same way. English-speaking Cornishmen, he tells us, have 'taken vp certayne peculiar phrases, which require a speciall Dictionaire for their interpretation'. He even offers a few entries for this hypothetical dictionary: *bezibd*, *road*, *scrip*, *pridy*, *boobish*, *dule*, *lidden shune*, *shew*, *skew*, and *hoase* are thus Cornishisms respectively for 'fortuned', 'ayme', 'escape', 'handsome', 'lubberly', 'comfort', 'by-word', 'strange', 'threaten', 'shunne', and 'forbeare' (56^v). Carew's treatment of the Cornish language is thus an exclusively lexical exercise and an elementary one at that. It is perhaps what one would expect from a young Oxonian inspired by an elder classmate who was already under the spell of the great work of his life, a Welsh dictionary.

Carew's lexical approach to the Cornish language is continually visible throughout the *Survey* in his often mentioned interest in etymologies, and these are not necessarily merely elementary examples.⁴² One finds them on almost every page. To name a few: he tells us that Cornishmen refer to their county as *Kernow*, derived from *Kerne* (horn), which describes the shape of the county which is 'cast out into the Sea, with the shape of a horne' (1^V). Cornish personal names begin with '*Tre, Pol, or Pen*, which signifie a towne, a Top, and a head' (55^r). Because of its ebbing and flowing, '*Dosmery poole*' is derived from '*Doz*, is, come, and *maur*, great' (122^r). The Hundred of Trigge is named for *Trig*, the Cornish word for 'inhabitant'. Bodmin, he thinks, comes from *Bos venna* (123^v), and the place name *Killigarth* means 'He hath lost his griping, or reaching' (130^r). St Michael's Mount's name in Cornish is '*Cora Cowz* in *Clowze*, that is, The hoare rocke in the wood' (154^r). As he began the *Survey* with the etymology of 'Cornwall', he closes with the etymology of a place name 'not farre from the lands ende ... *Chiwarton* signifyeth a house on the greene lay, and a Castle on a greene hill' (159^r). In these etymologies we see into the very heart of Carew's engagement with the Cornish language. He delights in the names of places and things, and as he writes, he provides a little dictionary of Cornish names — or rather the meanings of names. His friend, the lexicographer Thomas Wiliems, would undoubtedly approve.

Once we understand that Carew was not interested in conversing in Cornish but merely in collecting illustrative words, we can see why he shows little interest in grammar, syntax, tenses, cases — all those things that one would need in order to develop conversational facility in the Cornish language. Carew, moreover, shows little interest in actually communicating with anyone in that language. English, after all, had driven Cornish 'into the vttermost skirts of the shire'. Only a few of the 'old countrey people' insist on speaking Cornish, and when they do so, Carew suspects, it is an affectation designed to irritate an Anglophone gentleman like himself. 'The English which they speake, is good and pure', he insists, because they have received it 'from the best hands of their owne Gentry, and the Easterne Marchants' (56^r). It is highly unlikely, therefore, that Carew would have had knowledge enough to listen to a Cornish play, and even less interest in attending one primarily designed, as he thinks, to delight the 'Country people' with 'deuils and deuices, to delight as well the eye as the eare' (71^v). In this respect, it is perhaps telling that he represents the dialogue between the 'pleasant conceyted gentleman' and the frustrated Ordinary in English instead of in Cornish with English translation, as he often does.

4. The *Guary miracle*, in English, 'a miracle-play'

Carew's interest in etymology is especially important if we are to understand what he tells us about the *Guary miracle*. In the Cornish language, any play might be called a *guary* (also spelled *gwary* or *guare*), even a relatively brief farce. *Guary* is subject to all of the meanings of the English word, *play*, and so may refer to sports, games, and amusements, among other meanings, as well as to dramatic activity of all kinds. In the *passio Domini Nostri Jhesu Christi*, for instance, the First Tortor can exhort his fellows, *dun yn rak gans an guary* ('Let us go forward with the play', line 1388), referring to their 'game' of buffeting the blindfolded Christ, while at the end of the same play Nicodemus can send the audience home until the morrow because *an guary yw dywythys* ('the play is ended', lines 3237–8). As Joyce and Newlyn point out, a Cornish *plain-an-guary* (*playing place*) might therefore host many different activities: not only dramatic performances, but also such sports as hurling, wrestling, shooting, and other forms of play.⁴³ Theatrical performances staged in these *plains-an-guary* were known as *guary-mirkles*, a term that Carew transliterates as 'guary miracle'.⁴⁴

Carew regards *guary miracle* as a purely Cornish term, not an English one. He writes down what he has heard in Cornish (*guary-mirkle*) and it comes out on the page as *guary miracle*. Only when he says that the *guary miracle* should be construed 'in English, a miracle-play' is he translating into English what he rightly thinks of as an entirely Cornish term: *miracle* (*mirkle*) means 'miracle' in English and *guary* means 'play'. Since adjectives follow nouns in Cornish whereas they precede nouns in English, he must invert the order of the words so that his translation comes out as 'in English, a miracle-play'.

Carew is thus merely construing a Cornish term; he is not comparing a Cornish genre with an English one, not the least because *miracle play* was not a recognised generic term in England until the late-eighteenth century.⁴⁵ *Guary-mirkle* seems to have been a recognised Cornish one, however. Another writer thus independently repeats Carew's act of construing the term for English readers. In a legal deposition of 1568, a Cornish deponent, then 78 years old, refers to a 'Mirable Play' performed 'in the Place' at Sancreed parish when he was a boy (hence about 1500). The performance took place outdoors, and the deponent's reference to 'the Place' tells us that it took place in the *plain-an-guary* there.⁴⁶ Because he chooses a French word for *mirkle* to describe the play performed on that occasion, perhaps he is searching for a dignified way to make the Cornish term clear to the readers of this English deposition.⁴⁷ A false echo of the

term appears in the work of the seventeenth-century antiquary, William Scawen. In lamenting the disappearance of the Cornish language, Scawen calls these plays *Guirremears* ('great plays'), a term that he bizarrely mistranslates as 'Speeches great'.⁴⁸

Carew's understanding of the Cornish *guary-mirkle* was understandably a little sketchy. He had neither seen a performance nor read the text of any Cornish play. He nevertheless has heard enough about the *guary-mirkle* to describe its five generic characteristics: 1) it is 'compiled in Cornish;' 2) it takes as its subject 'some scripture history;' 3) along with the religious matter, it contains low comic material comparable to the Roman *vetus Comedia*: 'deuils and deuices, to delight as well the eye as the eare;' 4) it is performed in 'an earthen Amphitheatre, in some open field'; and 5) 'the actors do not memorise their lines but are prompted by 'one called the Ordinary'. The four major texts of Medieval Cornish Drama — the *Ordinalia*, *Beunans Meriasek*, *Bewnans Ke*, and *The Creacion of the World* — can be recognised in Carew's description, albeit imperfectly.⁴⁹ They are all written in Cornish, but two are saints' legends rather than scriptural histories. Even if we extend Carew's 'scripture history' to include saints' legends, moreover, the plays often include chivalric and secular plot segments, perhaps with contemporary political resonances. King Arthur plays an extensive part in *Bewnans Ke*, for instance, and the wicked tyrant King Teudar appears as an antagonist both in *Ke* and *Meriasek*. They all contain amusing, even low-comic characters and episodes, but the impression Carew gives that the plays as a whole resemble the Roman *vetus Comedia* is far-fetched at best. In their mixture of solemn and comic action, the extant Cornish plays resemble contemporaneous English plays like the *N.Town Passion Play*, *Mary Magdalene*, and *The Conversion of St Paul*.

One would like to see Carew reflecting genuine *guary-mirkle* theatrical conventions in narrating the 'mery pranke' of the 'pleasant conceyted gentleman'. In Carew's imagined performance, the actor awaits his cue, and when 'his turne came' the Ordinary gives him his first direction: 'Go forth man and shew thyselfe'. Just possibly, this line may be a rather distant echo of an authentic Cornish stage direction. In *Beunans Meriasek*, the text commonly uses *pompabit* as a stage direction to mark the first appearance of a character upon his *tentum*: *Pater mereadoci pompabit hic* (sd at line 1). The Latin verb, *pompo*, does not necessarily imply vanity, since good characters as well as evil ones 'will pomp about here'. It means, generally, to create a splendid show: to 'parade', 'display', make a splendid show', hence 'to pomp about'. Conceivably, therefore, it just might mean

'go forth man and shew thyselfe'. But if the actor takes the cue this way, Carew does not seem to do so. In the context of Carew's anecdote, the expression seems to mean no more than 'get yourself on stage'.

If the Ordinary were in full view of the audience while whispering lines and directions in the ears of actors already performing on the stage, however, surely he would bid an offstage actor to 'Come forth man and shew thy selfe'. This command, moreover, makes it clear that Carew envisions both actor and Ordinary as being off stage before making his first appearance: after the Ordinary tells the gentleman to 'go forth', the actor then 'steps out vpon the stage' where he first becomes visible to the audience. Clearly, Carew is imagining that the actor emerges from backstage concealment; it is, moreover, not clear that, in Carew's imagination, the Ordinary himself ever steps out upon the stage with him.

What does Carew mean by 'stage'? He seems to envision a platform stage with a backstage hidden by a curtain or screen. As he imagines this performance, actors emerge from the doors or curtains at the back of the stage, and they are prompted, at least initially, from behind the scenes. Carew seems entirely unaware of how the 'Guary' stage worked, as documented in the staging diagrams we possess for the *Ordinalia* and *Beunans Meriasek*. These 'mandate an outdoor area large enough for battles and for actors to ride around on horseback, with raised *loca* ... on the periphery, to and from which actors would ascend and descend'.⁵⁰ The texts refer to these *loca* variously: *tentum*, *pulpitum*, *sedes*, or *domum*.⁵¹ *Pulpitum* suggests a raised platform, while *tentum*, Bakere thinks, 'is clearly enclosed, probably with curtains which can be drawn back to revel the characters within'.⁵² In an 'earthen Amphitheatre' such as the one Carew himself describes, actors do not necessarily emerge from concealment backstage and perform on a platform, but they are present in their scenic *loci* as the play begins, and they begin their performances as 'stage directions call for characters to come down and to enter the *platea*'.⁵³ Often, the actors commute for considerable distances between scenic structures within the 'enclosed playne'. 'On stage' thus means a number of different things in the Cornish theatrical context. It may mean up on the *pulpitum* platform, down on the amphitheatre's *pleyn*, or perhaps in the act of ascending or descending between these places. At best, we can perhaps surmise that Carew imagines that a Cornish theatre was just an English platform stage, except that it was erected in the middle of a 'earthen Amphitheatre'.

Perhaps, however, Carew captures a distinctively Cornish acting convention in narrating the Ordinary's whispers. After the 'pleasant

conceyted gentleman' enters and 'pronounces aloud' the Ordinary's instruction to 'go forth and shew thyself', Carew tells us that the Ordinary 'says the fellow softly in his eare' a correction: 'Oh ... you marre all the play'. Perhaps, then, Carew imagines the Ordinary as showing himself onstage behind the actor. This is not entirely clear, however. The Ordinary may simply be 'flat rayling & cursing' behind the curtain, while the actor with a 'set gesture and countenance' repeats the lines aloud to comic effect.

Of all the Cornish stage conventions that Carew might have described — if he had actually seen a Guary performance — he includes only this one in his description, and he does so not very convincingly. He has heard something from somewhere about the Ordinary with his book dictating lines to actors, but Carew, as we have seen, actually knows very little about the Cornish 'guary miracle'. In describing the Ordinary's function, he incorporates him into an essentially English platform stage where actors conventionally make their exits and entrances through a curtained screen at the back to 'shew themselves' while unseen prompters whisper directions and lines from back stage. Carew may have seen performances of this kind in London, and he almost certainly did see such stage performances in Oxford.⁵⁴ He may also be thinking of performances of travelling actors' troupes in great halls.

On English stages, sixteenth-century prompter-bookholders conventionally station themselves behind a grilled door or a curtain just off stage. As Tiffany Stern tells us: 'the book-holder's position during performance' was situated

behind a curtain that divided some part of the tiring room from the stage. From here he could listen to a performance — and watch it to through a slit in the material. For the prompter needed to hear what was going on, so that he could help actors who forgot their lines.

The very nature of the activities that Carew imagines the Ordinary performing are quintessentially ones that the sixteenth-century bookholder-prompter was expected to perform. Thus even more important than cuing dropped lines, Stern tells us, the bookkeeper

needed to be in a position to see the action, for he cued not only entrances but also timing and blocking. One prologue asks for silence because 'I heare the players prest, in presence foorth to come'; indeed, the play-house book-keeper who 'would stampe and stare ... when the actors misse their entrance', is the stuff of theatrical comedy.⁵⁵

From this point of view, Carew's Ordinary anecdote is merely another version of a well-known Early Modern comic *topos*.

The more we examine the anecdote, the more we see Carew struggling to imagine how a prompter — a figure he knows only as a backstage functionary — might also operate as an onstage figure. He can only do this by imagining him operating in both ways during the same performance; if you inquire too deeply into the practicalities of this decision, however, this compromise does not work very well. The Ordinary would presumably have to cue entrances, and for this he needs to be backstage, because that is where he performs this function on sixteenth-century English stages. But he also needs to be onstage in order to whisper lines into the ears of actors who have not learned their parts beforehand. The scene, as we have seen above, is in progress before the gentleman is called upon to play his part. The Ordinary and the 'pleasant conceyted gentleman' are clearly backstage, because the Ordinary whispers in his ear a command to 'Goe forth man and shew thy selfe'. But because the play is already in progress, presumably the Ordinary must have been whispering lines and directions into the ears of actors already on stage. How has this been managed? Has he left the actors on stage to dash backstage to prompt the gentleman to 'go forth and shew thyself'? At every new entrance, he presumably would have to run backstage and escort the new actor out. This does not seem very likely.

This analysis, of course, imposes a very literal reading on Carew's anecdote, which may not be meant to be taken very literally. The point of the anecdote is after all to tell an amusing tale *about* the performance of a 'Guary', thereby providing the reader with 'more sport and laughter, then 20. such Guaries could haue affoorded'. Carew simply cannot provide us with the kind of careful description of a *guary-mirkle* in performance because he has not himself seen one. The information comes to him at second or third hand, and to us at third or fourth. But even this concession creates an important problem for the theatre historian. To what extent can we trust such a description to provide us with useful information? What we have to keep in mind is that Carew may well have heard correct information about the Cornish Ordinary's method of prompting actors, but that Carew himself simply couldn't imagine how it might practically work.

5. The Ordinary

Whether or not one accepts the Ordinary's function as described by Carew, his title strikes one as convincing. If Carew were merely describing

him, surely he would have chosen a less puzzling title. He might simply have called him the prompter, the superintendent, the leader, or the master, for instance.⁵⁶ That Carew introduces him as ‘one called the Ordinary’, suggests that he must actually have heard someone call him by that name and that it was a recognised title for the prompter-director of a Cornish *guary-mirkle*. The title also gains credibility, moreover, for its rarity; nowhere else in Europe is such a theatrical figure called the Ordinary. Perhaps the unusual title thus reflects the unusual nature of the Ordinary’s duties in leading the performance of a Cornish Guary. Finally, it seems genuine because it is a Latin rather than an English or Cornish word. For once, however, Carew does not attempt to supply an etymology for this unfamiliar title. As an Oxford scholar, perhaps he thought that the meaning of a Latin term would be clear to his readers.

If Carew thought that his readers would recognise the term, modern scholars have largely avoided engaging with it. One might think that Chambers and Wickham would enjoy teasing out the meanings of this unusual theatrical term, but after quoting Carew, they pass it over without etymological comment.⁵⁷ Philip Butterworth correctly notes that the *OED* definitions describe an *Ordinary* predominantly as a person ‘possessing legal or ecclesiastical authority’, but passes over these meanings as if irrelevant in a dramatic context.⁵⁸ Robert Longworth, however, suggests a fruitful connection between the manuscript, the Church service *ordinale*, and Carew’s *Ordinary*. The *ordinale*, he points out, ‘was the book upon which depended the proper execution of a community’s services of worship’ and it therefore ‘functioned as a kind of stage manager’s guide to the rites and ceremonies of the church’, just as the manuscript provides ‘the written text of the drama’, the script, so to speak, for the ‘rites and ceremonies’ of the dramatic performance presided over by the Ordinary.⁵⁹ I believe that Longworth is broadly correct in suggesting these connections. It is especially difficult to resist Longworth’s point that an Ordinary is the proper person to be in charge of an *ordinale*, which is the title given in the manuscript to two of the three plays that we now call the *Ordinalia*.⁶⁰

If we are to understand why Carew remembers the Ordinary as having exclusive and single-handed control over the playbook and its text, then we need to know what an Ordinary is. In ecclesiastical usage, an Ordinary is a person exercising ordinary rather than delegated jurisdiction, meaning that he has the power in his own right to legislate, adjudicate, and govern. There are two kinds. First, territorial ordinaries (*ordinarii locorum*), such as a pope, an archbishop in his province, and a bishop in his diocese, have

ordinary authority over their clergy in their territories. Second, other ordinaries — abbots, generals, and provincials of religious orders, for instance — exercise their powers not over a territory but over a religious community.⁶¹ The Ordinary wields absolute governing power over those subject to his authority. He has the quasi-regal power to make law, execute law, and render judgment based on the law. He can dispense offices, dignities, parsonages, and benefices to those who serve him well, and he can dispense punishment as he sees fit to those who serve him ill. He is also the head of an administrative hierarchy.

It is possible, but highly unlikely, that Carew's Ordinary is simply one of these clerical officers who has been given the prompting job in a *guary-mirkle* either as an honour or to exercise due diligence and control over the text of what is, after all, a performance of 'some scripture history', as Carew puts it. Carew's wording, however, does not support this identification very well — 'one *called* the Ordinary' — so we should probably be thinking of an allusive significance for this title when used in a theatrical sense. In calling him the Ordinary, Carew's informant thus almost certainly meant to depict him as exercising 'ordinary' authority over both the actors and the play. Since he exercises his authority only over those acting in, and perhaps producing, the *guary-mirkle*, he would be an ordinary analogous to that of an abbot in his convent rather than that of an *ordinarius loci* such as a bishop in his diocese. His members of his convent, so to speak, are the actors who move when and where he tells them, and they parrot the words that he whispers in their ears. He meanwhile reserves to himself the power of interpreting the book which he carries 'in his hand' while the players are apparently prohibited from reading it themselves. He makes them move and speak as directed by the book he carries.

This considerable textual authority provides a particularly interesting point of contact between the ecclesiastical and theatrical Ordinaries. Ecclesiastical ordinaries commonly exercised textual authority in two important cases: literacy and orthodoxy. In the first instance, the Ordinary was capable of verifying whether clergy were competent in both reading and syllabifying (*legere aut silabicare*) Latin texts. As Katherine Zieman tells us, it usually fell to the ecclesiastical Ordinary 'to determine what distinguished clerical reading — that is, authoritative reading — from other textual encounters, and he had then to isolate that skill in order to verify it in dubious cases'. It was crucial that clergy could demonstrate not merely the ability to memorise snippets of texts, but actually read and pronounce them. This problem became acute in cases where a prisoner

claimed benefit of clergy. Zieman recounts the fate of one hapless claimant, who was 'given a psalter from which to read in order to prove his claim', but 'he could neither read nor syllabify in the book, except in certain places in which he had been instructed'. Those places alone he seemed to know 'without the book through repetition'. When given the book upside down, he 'continued to read the verses he had learned, oblivious to the book's orientation', at which point 'the ecclesiastical Ordinary refused to claim him as clergy and he remained under secular jurisdiction, having been declared "a layman and not literate, knowing nothing of letters"'.⁶²

To ensure orthodoxy, Archbishop Arundel's Constitutions (1407–1409) decreed that 'no manner of person, secular or regular ... shall take upon him the office of preaching the word of God ... whether within the church or without, in English, except he first present himself, and be examined by the ordinary of the place where he preacheth'. This measure was adopted to combat the Lollard heresies and teaching at Oxford, and to that end specifically declared that 'no preacher aforesaid, or any other person whatsoever, shall otherwise teach or preach concerning the sacrament of the altar, matrimony, confession of sins, or any other sacrament of the church, or article of the faith, than what already is discussed by the holy mother church; nor shall bring any thing in doubt that is determined by the church'.⁶³ Nicolas Watson observes that potentially, at least, the composition and ownership of literary works that use biblical quotation and treat theological subjects became, 'in principle, directly illegal', unless approved of by the relevant local Ordinary, and the Constitutions seems to have brought about a 'sharp decline both in the quantity of large theological works written in the vernacular and in their scope and originality'.⁶⁴ By Carew's time, of course, the religious climate in England had changed remarkably, and steps taken in the Constitutions to protect religious orthodoxy were now used to protect a Reformed orthodoxy, or at least a desire to suppress religious controversy. Students of the medieval drama will accordingly think of the steps taken by Reformed Ordinaries (e.g. the attempt by Edmund Grindal, Archbishop of York to suppress the Chester plays in 1572 and the unsuccessful attempt by the citizens of York to secure permission from Grindal's successor, Edwin Sandys, to allow the plays in 1579–1580)⁶⁵ to suppress popular civic religious drama sequences at York, Chester, Coventry, and elsewhere.

These textual responsibilities, however, do not entirely explain why a theatrical prompter would be called the play's Ordinary; that term, as we

have seen, designates a person who exercises absolute governing power over those subject to his authority. The parallel ecclesiastical usage suggests considerably more comprehensive powers than the monitoring of textual performance. A bishop may well examine whether clergy in his province possess the necessary skills to read and syllabify, but this is only a relatively minor part of his duties, and one, moreover, that he might delegate if he sees fit. If so, however, his deputy would possess only derivative powers and would not be regarded as an Ordinary. The Ordinary in a diocese or an abbacy uses his absolute powers to manage, legislate, and govern over a large ecclesiastical enterprise. In this respect, it is difficult to see how 'one called the Ordinary' could possibly have responsibilities limited solely to prompting actors in the way that Carew imagines. If the prompter-stage director is called 'the Ordinary', then what does one call a medieval Cornish version of the theatrical producer? Surely the term 'Ordinary' must suggest not simply textual authority, but comprehensive authority for the production and performance of the play.

Although 'Ordinary' does not appear elsewhere among the records of the medieval drama, a number of similar terms appear throughout Western Europe to indicate those who had ordinary power over medieval plays, particularly large-scale outdoor productions. In France, for instance, such men were called variously *supervisors*, *originateurs*, *meneurs* (or *mestres*) *du jeu*, and *superintendants*.⁶⁶ In Lucerne, the Town Clerk Renward Cysat styled himself the play's *Regent*.⁶⁷ His regal title reflected his total control of all features of the production: set design, costuming, stage management, special effects, rehearsal, prompting, and directing, among them.⁶⁸ Often, titles were unimportant. Jakob Ruf, who wrote, directed, and produced a series of large-scale, outdoor, religious plays in Zurich in the mid-sixteenth century, did not have such a title, but he exercised control over all aspects of the production and performance nevertheless.⁶⁹ Like Thomas Colclow at Coventry in 1453, one might simply be given 'þe Rewle of þe pajaunt unto þe end of xij yers next folowing' without the grandeur of a specific title. Colclow's duties as specified in the grant required him 'to find þe pleyers and all þat longeth þerto'. He had custody of the 'originall' (i.e., the authorised script) and was required to return it and the 'garments þat longen to þe pajant as good as þey wer delyvered to hym'. He was paid annually 'ffor his labor xlvj s viij d', a handsome sum in the fifteenth century.⁷⁰ Like Cysat, he clearly *rewled* over his production, albeit without the title.

One can judge how closely this theatrical regency mirrors the ecclesiastical Ordinary's powers in a contract drawn up between the *superintendants* and actors in the Valenciennes *Mystère de la Passion* of 1547. Because the production was very large and complex, comprising as it did no less than 25 *journées*, the powers were divided among thirteen *superintendants* and three *originateurs*; this division may perhaps reflect that each *superintendant* was responsible for overseeing the equivalent of two plays. As specified in the contract, the actors were under oath to obey the decisions and directions of the *superintendants*, who were empowered to punish and fine the actors 'for any misdemeanor without recourse to the magistrates'. They swore a solemn oath, for instance, to accept whatever roles the *superintendants* assigned them, to appear at rehearsals, to be present for performances, refrain from meddling with or complaining against whatever the *superintendants* may decide, not to meddle with the taking of the entrance money, and to accept their decisions with respect to disputes between actors. In order to enforce these rules, the *superintendants* might levy fines or other punishments as necessary, and if the play should make a profit, the *supervisors* could reward the actors *selon leur mérite* ('according to their merits').⁷¹ The Valenciennes *superintendant*, like the ecclesiastical Ordinary, thus enjoyed comprehensive jurisdiction over the actors, including the powers to legislate, punish, and reward as they see fit without recourse to any superior power.

One suspects that the production of large scale medieval religious dramas were commonly, if not universally, organised in something like this manner: here a producer-director with ordinary powers to oversee all elements of the performance; there a committee of co-equal colleagues sharing among themselves these powers; still elsewhere a divided *rewle*, perhaps with one person overseeing the costuming, rehearsals, and actors, another to oversee the pageant wagon or (scenic *loca*) and finances; each invested with considerably regal powers over his subordinates to ensure that the production was successful and on time. Many variations of this scheme are obviously possible, but they all have in common nearly unchallenged power invested in some one or some small group. The titles that these men bear when exercising such powers are relatively unimportant, and as we have seen, some bear no title at all. We should be paying less attention to such titles themselves as to what the titles represent. That Carew tells us that 'one called the Ordinary' was in charge of the actors points to just such organisational structure as we have been

examining, and it further suggests powers more comprehensive than prompting actors alone.

We can find some corroborative evidence of yet another Cornish producer-director with comprehensive 'ordinary' powers among two stage directions in *The Creacion of the World* where he is called 'the conveyour':

Adam and Eva aparlet in whytt lether / in a place apoynted by the
conveyour / & not to be sene tyll they be called / & thei knell & ryse

Lett Adam laye downe & slepe wher Eva ys / & she by the
conveyour, / must be taken from Adam is syde.⁷²

These two stage directions, as we shall see below, refer to two quite different contributions made by the conveyour in the production and performance of the play: the first refers exclusively to his role as the play's production manager; the second refers to his role as actor in the play.

As Philip Butterworth observes, 'the relationship between Carew's "Ordinary" and the "conveyour" ... has been much discussed' from E.K. Chambers' *Mediaeval Stage* (1903) to the present.⁷³ Most scholars now agree that *Conveyour*, like *Ordinary*, probably serves as one of those terms that indicate a person with comprehensive authority over the production of the play. Both Neuss and Butterworth have thus rehearsed the semantic evidence that *Conveyour* could, like *Ordinary*, refer to a 'director-stage manager' in the fifteenth century. Both cite items in the York and New Romney records to demonstrate that *conveyour* and *conveyance* were used in this sense in the fifteenth century. At York in 1486, the city council agreed that 'sir Henrie Hudson prest ... shuld haue the *conueance* of the making and directing of the shew to be maide ayenst the kinges commyng heder' (i.e. the pageantry for Henry VII's entry into York in 1486). At New Romney in 1560, John Whatman and John Aunderson were appointed 'to be Conveyers of the workes' for the town's renowned Passion Play.⁷⁴ One might also revisit an often-cited reference to Robert Hewyk and his two assistants being hired for the *educcione* of the York Doomsday pageant in 1454. The REED editors quite properly translate this Latin word as *production* for twentieth-century readers. Given the primary meanings of *educo* ('to draw out, bring up, foster, rear'), however, a fifteenth-century translator, might well choose to translate *educcione* as *conveyance* in this theatrical context.⁷⁵

The first of the two stage directions in which the *Conveyour* appears demonstrates convincingly that he wielded control over production design, not just prompting and directing. The text thus defers to the *Conveyour*

the selection — and perhaps the design — of a specific place, probably somewhere in the scenic *locus* representing Paradise, where Adam and Eve can be hidden ‘tyll they be called / & thei knell & ryse’.⁷⁶ One finds such directions fairly frequently in French *mystères*. Take this stage direction, for instance, from the manuscript of Nicolas Loupvent’s *St Étienne* (1548) in which a group of Christians are to descend beneath the stage into the catacombs:

s’en vont absconser et cachier en la cripte nepotiane qui serat quelque conuavité et creux dessoulz les escharfaulx; ou aultrement sy le jeux et mistere se faisoit bas sur terre, on les pouroit mestre derriere quelque tapisserie.

‘They go away to conceal and hide themselves in the *cripte nepotiane* [i.e. catacombs] that will be some concavity and hollow place beneath the scaffolds; or otherwise, if the play and *mystère* is made flush to the ground, they can be put behind some tapestry.’

Or consider another stage direction from the same play that ponders a vital point of costuming, which he leaves to the *mestre/meneur du jeu* (both versions of the title appear), Jacques Buffelot, to ponder. As Nemesius kneels before St Étienne to be baptized, a sacristan gives the saint *une ayguyeir pleine d’eau ... pour luy en getter sur le teste* (‘a tankard full of water ... to pour over his head’). How should Nemesius be costumed at this point, Loupvent wonders: *Sy semble bon à maistre Jacques Buffelot ou à maistgre Ligier que le dict Nemesius douyve estre nudz, ilz le poront ordonner* (‘If it seems good to maistre Jacques Buffelot or to maistre Ligier that the said Nemesius ought to be naked, they can so order it’).⁷⁷ Or consider a stage direction from the anonymous *Mistère de la Conception* (c. 1503) that instructs three actors to clear away the Temple vessels that have just been on display during a scene in which the Feast of the Tabernacle has been performed. The one portraying an Archdeacon orders the minor clergy to put *lez reliqueres et saintex choses* (reliquaries and holy things) in *coffre* and *casse*. A stage direction at this point mandates that the removal of these coffers and chests containing these reliquaries and holy things must be done *a la disposition du mestre du jeu* (‘as the *mestre du jeu* assigns’).⁷⁸ This direction suggests that the reliquaries and vessels are not just property imitations, but real ones borrowed from the local church. They therefore require special care and thoughtful consideration, and the *mestre du jeu* should properly take responsibility for seeing that they are properly looked after.

All these stage directions, Cornish and French alike, are prospective. At the time that the script was written, some important details had not been decided, and so they were specifically left to the *conveyour*, *mestre du jeu*, or *meneur du jeu* to decide. These figures are rarely mentioned in play texts, and when they are, it is generally by title, not name, particularly if future performances of the script are contemplated. In only one of these three texts is he referred to by name. In referring to him as 'the Conveyour', the manuscript of the *Creacion of the World* thus closely resembles these French play manuscripts.

Butterworth has proposed that the second of the two Cornish stage directions we are considering likewise 'illuminates the [conveyour's] stage management/directorial function "in full view of the audience"',⁷⁹ but it does not. It tells us, rather, that the *conveyour*, in addition to his managerial duties, serves as an actor in the play, a point first made by Paula Neuss.⁸⁰ The stage direction prompts a theatrical imitation of one of the most familiar images in the late-medieval visual repertoire: the Creation of Eve. It frequently appears in books of hours, stained glass windows, the *Speculum humanae salvationis*, and the *Biblia pauperum*.⁸¹ If we understand that the *conveyour* plays the role of God the Father in the play, then we will see that the stage direction describes the conventional image precisely. The text stages this episode by having Adam return to lie down and sleep 'wher Eva ys', and she remains there until the *conveyour* then takes Eve 'from Adam is syde'. As in the previous stage direction, the scribe merely refers to the actor by his official title rather than his character's name. The stage direction directs Adam to lie down and 'sleep' beside the shallow pit in which both he and Eve were initially hidden. Adam has been already been called to 'knell and ryse' from that pit at line 352 when God created him, but Eve thus far remains hidden. Now the *conveyour* reaches down behind the sleeping Adam, grasps Eve's hand, and pulls her up, first kneeling, then standing. In his way, Eve 'by the *conveyour* must be taken from Adam is side'. To the audience it would seem as if God is pulling her out of Adam's body, thus effecting an impressive dramatic version of the common visual image.

It is one thing for a *conveyour* to take a part in a play; it is another, however, to suppose that the audience must have perceived that the role of God was performed by the play's *conveyour*. True, it is tempting to think of the *conveyour* acting the role of God as metatheatrical expression of his own God-like powers as director. And this thought has led some to assume that, as Butterworth puts it, 'the role of the "Ordinary" was capable of

being subsumed by the role of the “conveyour”, who in turn took on the role of “God” so that ‘individuals in the audience would have been free to determine for themselves whether they witnessed the “conveyour” creating Eva out of Adam or whether the same person created Eva in his role of “God”’.⁸² But how many ‘individuals in the audience’ would be in a position to know that the actor playing God was also the play’s *conveyour*? Would all those ‘country people’ whom Carew tells us regularly flocked from all sides to see the play actually be aware of his dual theatrical identity? To the contrary, there is good reason to suppose that directors of plays often played roles in these plays. Nine of the thirteen *superintendants* in the Valenciennes *Passion* took parts in that play, and not just minor roles. Jehan Sterlin played such *grandes parchons* (major roles) as Herod Antipas, Jayrus, and Antipater, among others.⁸³ Some evidence suggests that the masters and supervisors of *mystères* were essentially performers who were elected from their fellow actors.⁸⁴ Paula Neuss similarly mentions Robert Croo of Coventry who took various production roles (writing scripts, costuming, scenery) in the Corpus Christi pageants and also played the role of God in the *Doomsday* play.⁸⁵

All this metatheatrical speculation depends upon an assumption that the *conveyour* of the *Creacion of the World* must have directed the actors in the same way that Carew says the Ordinary prompted the actors by following them ‘at their back with the booke in his hand’, prompting them ‘softly what they must pronounce aloud’. Although no evidence whatsoever for this practice appears in the text or stage directions of the *Creacion*, nevertheless the assumption grows into a presumption: the *conveyour*, we are told, presumably performed ‘with the booke in his hand’. From there, we are invited to ponder a sequence of speculations: ‘Did he learn his lines or read them? Given his other functions, is he not likely to have read them from the book? Alternatively, the book may have been used as an aide-memoire or used selectively in order to indicate that the book was being used as the Bible ... However, the [*conveyour*’s] fusion of organisational, theatrical and biblical narrative functions indicates the imaginative uniqueness of such a possible role’.⁸⁶

But why should we assume that God carries a book around on stage? Such a prop is not mentioned in the text. The Father of Heaven ‘requires’ such a prop in the *Creacion* only because Carew’s anecdote tells us that the Ordinary carried one, not because the text or stage directions of the *Creacion* to suggest that God either carries a book or reads from one.

Books do serve as important props in the play. Just before the Flood, Lamech writes down ‘everything ... from the beginning of this world ... lest it should be forgotten’. Four ‘amazingly big’ books are ‘shewed’ and placed in ‘two pillars made — the one of brick, and the other of marble’ — to safeguard them (2171–97). Books in the play thus belong to the fallen world and are required because mortals forget. A God who has to consult a book may therefore seem diminished in authority if he relies upon a mortal prop rather than his own divine mind. As God’s own book, moreover, the temptation would be to make it even more ‘amazingly big’ than Lamech’s books. Carrying such a prop may even prove awkward when the Father creates heaven and earth (lines 1–112), sends Lucifer to hell (lines 284–335), makes man from clay and breathes into his body (lines 346–48), takes a rib and lifts Eve from Adam’s side (sds at lines 389, 392), and writes *omega* on Cain’s forehead (sd at line 1179). Surely if the Father habitually carries a book, the script would contrive to make symbolic or practical use of it.

6. ‘A kind of Enterlude’

Such difficulties raise a more general question about the way actors performed their roles in the Cornish drama. Can we confidently say, as some scholars do, that Carew’s Ordinary ‘clearly ... prompted in full view of the audience’ by following ‘the player around the performance space which is designated by Carew as “an earthen Amphitheatre, in some open field, hauing the Diameter of his enclosed playne some 40. or 50. foot?”’⁸⁷ One would expect that proponents of this view would be eager to demonstrate that the extant Cornish plays were well-suited to this practice, thereby dismissing the reservations mentioned above. The extant manuscripts are full of stage directions, like the ones discussed above; many of the actors’ lines indicate stage business, and there are wonderful stage directions in two of the extant manuscript. Surely these manuscripts must have something to say about how the viability of Carew’s Ordinary, and they may as well have something to say about whether the actors learned their lines or were merely expected to ‘pronounce aloud’ what the Ordinary ‘tellet them softly’.

Those who regard Carew’s anecdote as ‘factual information concerning the activity of the Ordinary and his relationship with the player’, however, have largely avoided grasping this particular nettle. Sometimes questions relevant to answering these important questions are asked. Philip Butterworth, for instance, asks ‘what resulted if simultaneous action

needed to take place in another part of the playing space away from the player being prompted? Could such a convention have permitted simultaneous action in another part of the “enclosed playne”? He omits, however, to investigate this crucial problem. He does however speculate that, in a hypothetical production, long speeches may have ‘permitted the Ordinary to perform his duties’ while ‘shorter lines in exchange between characters are likely to have made for more frenetic activity from the Ordinary’.⁸⁸

Instead of embracing the hypothetical, Betcher declares that such investigations are ‘counterproductive’. She chides those scholars who ‘continue to compare the miracle play described by Carew with the content and action of the extant religious drama texts in Cornish’ which have ‘raised doubts about whether Carew’s assertions represent the circumstances of any actual dramatic production’. She therefore stipulates that ‘the likelihood that any of the extant records or descriptions are connected to the surviving Cornish play manuscripts has grown slimmer as more documentary evidence has been uncovered’. Far more promising, she thinks, is a payment in the 1572/3 St Ives Borough Accounts to ‘Iohn Clarke for ye enterlude’.⁸⁹

Carew, it is true, describes the ‘Guary Miracle’ as ‘a kind of Enterlude’. Putting the emphasis on *Enterlude* might thus seem to move the possibilities for the application of Carew’s anecdote to include more small-scale plays, secular as well as religious, perhaps even comic farces of the sort usually performed indoors by small companies of professional players. Perhaps, then, we ought to see the Ordinary as directing *interludes*. This definition belongs, of course, to what modern scholars call the ‘Tudor Interlude’.⁹⁰ *Interlude*, however, is a very elastic term in the sixteenth- and seventeenth-centuries, and ‘as a generic term is more diffuse than even modern drama scholars have allowed’.⁹¹ But the word is more often than not used in a non-generic sense as referring to plays in general. Chambers finds that ‘the term ... appears to be equally applicable to every kind of drama known to the Middle Ages’. In addition to farces, ‘somour games’, and moralities, he cites references to such large-scale outdoor religious plays as ‘the interlude of our Lord’s Passion at New Romney’.⁹² By the sixteenth-century, Sir Thomas Eliot was using *enterlude* to describe all kinds of classical drama: comedy, tragedy and ‘stage playes’ in general. As Nick Davis points out, in late-Tudor documents, ‘*plays and interludes*’ turns up frequently as a catch-all expression for every kind of drama’.⁹³

In a sentence in which he had already used *play* just five words previously, Carew understandably turns to *enterlude* as a stylistically graceful synonym. *Enterlude* serves him in this passage in much the same way that another writer might use *poetry*, as a generic term that can be subdivided into 'parts, kinds, or species' as Sydney puts it.⁹⁴ He then narrows his focus to a particular species of the *play* or *enterlude* genre peculiar to Cornwall, the *guary-mirkle*. Because he thinks that his English readers will be unfamiliar with this species of *enterlude*, he defines its characteristics and tells an anecdote that illustrates its peculiar mode of performance. There is no reason to imagine that Carew means to describe any Cornish *enterlude*, but only the specific species of *enterlude* known as a *guary-mirkle*. Unless it is a play in the Cornish language, takes its matter from 'some scriptural history', includes amusing devices and devils, and is staged in a large earthen amphitheatre under the direction of an Ordinary, it is not a *guary-mirkle* (or, as Carew translates that term, 'Guary Miracle'). The four extant Cornish play manuscripts — *The Ordinalia*, *Bewnans Ke*, *Beunans Meriasek*, and *The Creacion of the World* — clearly contain all of the characteristics that Carew mentions, with one possible exception: it is not immediately apparent that any of them were performed under the direction of an Ordinary as Carew says they were.⁹⁵

7. The extraordinary prompter

There is every reason to examine the texts, stage directions, and stage diagrams in the extant *guary-mirkle* manuscripts to see whether the plays have been designed to permit a performance directed by an Ordinary who feeds lines to actors who have not memorised them in advance, and manages to do this, moreover, even while he may also take a part in the play, as the *conveyour* apparently did in the *Creacion*. If we examine the plays from this point of view, it becomes clear that all of them include episodes that would make it awkward, difficult, even impossible, to accommodate an Ordinary who follows the actors 'at their back with the booke in his hand, and telleth them softly what they must pronounce aloud'. In all of the extant plays, for instance, actors regularly have to speak from the *platea* upward to other actors located upon a raised platform stage. Probably roofed and hung with curtains that can be closed, these *tenta* or *pulpita* are high enough that the space beneath them can be used as a jail, for instance, or for burying the body of a king.⁹⁶ If, as seems likely, the platforms are set atop the surrounding earthen bank, the *pulpita* would be at least five or six feet above the *platea*. The actors in

the play frequently refer to these structures as ‘towers’, as does the Messenger in *Beunans Meriasek* who leaves the Emperor Constantine to seek spiritual and medical assistance from the Bishop of Poli and his Doctor: ‘Hail, Sir Bishop in thy tower’, he greets them (1392). This term may occasionally serve only as an invitation to the audience’s imagination, but some of these structures, at least, must have seemed quite high.⁹⁷ In the *Creacion*, heaven may well have comprised a structure of two or three tiers.⁹⁸ From these structures, characters descend into the *platea*, and from there they *ascend* to the *pulpita*. For the most part, these movements would have required only ladders or stairs, but the tower of Heaven was high enough in the *Creacion* that God could make a spectacular ascent from earth to Heaven ‘in a clowde’ (sd at line 420), an exit that would have required some sort of winching mechanism.

Because actors above in pageants often carry on conversations with other actors down in the *platea*, Carew’s prompter would have considerable difficulties in prompting such exchanges. To cite just a few representative examples of many: in the *Origo Mundi*, the Bishop leaves Maximilla in mid-speech and ascends to his *tentum*; she remains in the *platea*. They continue their conversation until the Bishop calls his four *Tortors* (Executioners). They, too, converse with the Bishop above them until he orders them to drag Maximilla and stone her to death (lines 2655–2702), which they then proceed to do. In the *Passio Christi*, Annas and Caiphas take Jesus to Pilate. The two clerics ascend to Pilate’s *tentum*, leaving Jesus standing alone upon the *platea*. Pilate demands if Jesus thinks he is the King of the Jews, and Jesus answers enigmatically, ‘thou hast said it’ (1579–1616). In *Bewnans Ke*, Arthur descends from his *tentum* about line 2748, leaving Guenevere, Modred, and the Bishops on the *pulpitum* above him. He continues to converse with the Queen and the Bishops, then goes off to battle. Only then do the Bishops descend to the *platea* (about line 2778). When mortals are conversing with inhabitants of heaven, they usually stand on the *platea* in front of the *celum* and speak upward to God or Jesus, who speaks downward at them. Encounters like this are common in all of the extant Cornish plays, and if prompted as Carew imagines, they would apparently require the Ordinary to ascend and descend repeatedly between *platea* to *pulpitum*.

Even if we consider that the prompter might simply prompt upward to the person standing above him in a *tentum* while continuing to speak softly to the actor below, his problem grows more acute as the distance increases between these actors on different levels. In the *Creacion*, the Father in

Heaven/*Conveyour* has to prompt Noah on the Ark (lines 2457–531); he stands in the uppermost tier of Heaven while Noah's Ark has come to a rest somewhere in the *platea* (which is called the *playne* in this text). Similarly, the Father/*Conveyour* would have to prompt Lucifer, who is in the pit of Hell, immediately after he has himself departed to heaven in a cloud (sd at line 420). It seems unlikely that he could do so by prompting 'softly' from the top of a three-storey heaven *locus* on one side of Paradise, down to a devil in the pit of Hell on the other side of Paradise (e.g. lines 326–27 and 420–21).

Both *Beunans Meriasek* and the *Ordinalia* include scenes of prayer that are immediately responded to by God or Jesus.⁹⁹ In each case, the petitioner is located somewhere out in the *platea* while God or Jesus respond from a heaven *tentum* located on the rim of the earthwork surrounding the *plain-an-gwary*. *Beunans Meriasek* stages two such episodes in succession. First, Meriasek kneels in his oratory to beseech Jesus to 'keep my soul without corruption, | And my body likewise'. Jesus immediately dispatches Michael and Gabriel, who descend from heaven to the accompaniment of organs or singing to bring him 'the food of heaven' to sustain him during his fast (3860–95). In the following scene, Sylvester kneels in prayer at the Emperor Constantine's *tentum*, which is located diametrically across the *platea* from heaven. He asks Jesus for the power to destroy a dragon that has been ravaging the country. Across the *platea*, Jesus immediately directs Peter to reassure the saint. Peter descends from heaven, crosses to Silvester, and reassures him that he will meet the dragon and command him in the name of Christ to 'come out here to me', whereupon Silvester may 'lead her as thou wishest, | Right according to thy own will' (4003–4067). In the *Passio Christi*, Jesus prays at Gethsemane, which is located out in the *platea*, and God, from his heavenly *tentum* on the circumference of the *plain-an-gwary*, immediately responds by commanding Gabriel to descend from heaven, cross the *plain*, and offer Jesus 'who is praying to me ... the fairest joy thou knowest' (lines 1031–56). Such episodes make it virtually impossible for an Ordinary to prompt as Carew imagines.

Although the plays usually depict actions sequentially, there are a number of impressive examples of simultaneous staging that should prove exceptionally difficult for an Ordinary to prompt. In the *Passio's* staging of the Agony in the Garden, the action alternates quickly between Gethsemane, Heaven, and the Conspirators.¹⁰⁰ Gethsemane is located out in the *platea*, the Conspirators gather at Caiphaz's *tentum*, and Deus Pater

waits in his *celum* (heaven) *tentum*. These latter *loca*, according to the stage diagram, are located 90 degrees from one another on the periphery of the circular *plain-an-gwary*. As Jesus prays in Gethsemane, both angels and conspirators move from their *tenta* to converge upon the Mount of Olives (1011–1105). The action alternates quickly between Gethsemane, Heaven, and the Conspirators. Immediately after Jesus begins to pray in Gethsemane — ‘As I am thy Son, I pray thee, If it can be so, | Put this same death | Frome me, that I be not slain’ (lines 1033–36) — the action switches to Heaven, where (as we have seen), Deus Pater answers Jesus’ prayer by sending Gabriel to him. Gabriel descends from heaven, travels to Gethsemane, where Jesus has continued to pray, greets Jesus, and then returns to *celum*. As Jesus continues alternately to pray and stir his sleeping disciples, the focus shifts to the Conspirators, who are just leaving Caiphaz’s *tentum*. As they walk toward Gethsemane, Judas warns Annas and the executioners to pay attention to ‘Whomsoever I shall kiss’ (1081–6). As they walk onward, the focus shifts back to Jesus. For the third and last time, Jesus prays in Gethsemane and tells his Disciples to sleep because ‘I have prayed my Father enough’. Only at this point do the Conspirators arrive, and Judas kisses Jesus.

Other Cornish plays seem to share a fondness for simultaneous staging. Arthur’s betrayal by Modred and Guenevere at the end of *Bewnans Ke* seems to employ simultaneous staging from time to time, although the lack of a stage diagram and the sparseness of stage directions makes this unclear. The episode of the ‘Mother’s Son’ in *Beunans Meriasek*, however, takes particular interest in staging simultaneous actions, sometimes from opposite sides of the *plain-an-gwary*. At the very beginning of the episode, the virtuous King Massen displays himself (*Hic pompabit Rex Massen*) from his *tentum* and orders his Hunters to ready the hounds and his men to hunt in the forest (3156–70). Without a pause, the action shifts diametrically to the opposite side of the *plain-an-gwary* where a son is taking leave of his tearful mother to ‘go without grief | ... to the court of the king’ to make his way in the world. He leaves for King Massen’s scaffold, and at the same time his mother goes to the chapel in the centre of the *platea*, where she prays to the Virgin to keep her son safe, ‘all my trust is in thee’ (3171–95). While she is praying, the son arrives at the King Massen’s *tentum* where he offers his services to the king and is accepted as a ‘leal servant’ (3196–3207). The action then immediately switches to the Tyrant’s *tentum*, who like Massen decides to hunt in the forest. Both groups thus head for the forest, where they will meet and fight a battle,

King Massen will lose and retreat back to his own *tentum*, and the *filius mulieris* ('woman's son') will be taken captive (3208–3577). At the very beginning of the episode, our hypothetical Ordinary would thus have to prompt actors located in four different places, two of them diametrically opposite one another and a third located in the middle of the *platea*, apparently without allowing for a pause to allow him to move between these locations.

The effect of the play depends upon these instantaneous changes of location to establish the simultaneous nature of the actions that are occurring along with their attendant dramatic ironies (i.e. the two kings deciding to go to the same place at the same time, the mother's son who will be taken captive, condemned to death, but saved by the intercession of the Virgin thanks to his mother's prayer). Throughout the rest of the episode, these actions are staged sometimes sequentially, sometimes simultaneously. The play's fondness for staging simultaneous actions at the opposite sides of the *platea* continues throughout the episode.¹⁰¹ It seems unlikely that the play could be prompted by 'one called the Ordinary' and performed by actors who 'conne not their parts without booke' beforehand.

8. The ordinary player: conning his part beforehand

The evidence of the prompter's on-stage presence has so far been negative: a single Ordinary would find it difficult, even impossible, to prompt the extant plays in the way that Carew says he did. But positive evidence also exists that tells us much about the relationship between Cornish actors and the scripts of the plays they performed. To begin with, the presence of companies of travelling players who perform interludes in the great houses, boroughs, and towns of Cornwall, suggests that some audiences in Cornwall must have been familiar with actors who learned their lines in advance, thus making Cornish's Ordinary superfluous to these performances.¹⁰² Certainly the English travelling companies who toured through Cornwall — the 'kynges enterluyd plaers' and Lord Stafford's players, for instance — would have performed plays 'conning their parts'. Since Carew specifically tells us that only *guary-mirkles* were performed under the direction of an on-stage Ordinary, we should probably conclude that memorisation was normal for other kinds of plays, particularly indoor performances.

Conclusive evidence that — at least in the mid-fourteenth century — actors memorised their roles before performance exists in the so-called

'Charter Fragment'. The status of this text had been long unsettled: some had championed it as a fragment of a play, others thought it a poem. As late as 1994, Murdoch thought that 'every single one of the assumptions made about the fragment is questionable — that it is dramatic at all, that the whole passage is intended for a single speaker, that the speaker is a woman'.¹⁰³ Since then, however, Newlyn has studied 'details of the manuscript's presentation and aspects of its content that have been heretofore ignored or insufficiently considered', and in doing so she has conclusively demonstrated that the text is not a fragment of anything, but rather a coherent document: 'one person's part from a play with two other characters, an interlude requiring neither stage nor banquet, in the tradition of works about a female matchmaker'.¹⁰⁴ The text, in short, consists of the actor's 'part', that of a clever matchmaker who uses trickery to bring a couple together in a play, not unlike the Middle English *Interludium de Clerico et Puella* (c. 1300).

Actors' parts, as Tiffany Stern tells us, were the primary means by which actors learned their lines.

These 'parts' consisted of the individual actor's lines only, each speech preceded by a short 'watchword' or 'cue' of the last one to four words of the previous speaker's lines: actors would listen for the cue, and say the speech that they had learnt followed it. So roles were learnt in isolation not only from other performers, but from the rest of the play.¹⁰⁵

Actors' *parts* were remarkably consistent throughout Western Europe in the Late Middle Ages and the Early Modern period. They were certainly the commonplace method by which actors learned their parts in England. Philip Butterworth thus rehearses the evidence of *partes* (sometimes called *parcelles*) for actors in the biblical play sequences at York, Chester, Coventry, Bungay, Suffolk, and New Romney, Kent, among other places.¹⁰⁶ Palfrey and Stern have surveyed the extant actor's part manuscripts in England, France, and Germany.¹⁰⁷ They predominantly take the form of a roll of paper about 10cm wide. The matchmaker's part of the Charter Fragment — Newlyn would rightly prefer to refer to the text as *The Middle Cornish Interlude* — is clearly of this type.¹⁰⁸ Although written on the back of a legal charter, the text of the matchmaker's lines has been confined to an approximately three-inch-wide strip. The verse lines are actually compressed to fit within this narrow textual space of a much wider folio. The margins of the charter were then folded back so

that the actor would have only a narrow manuscript roll to deal with. Horizontal bars drawn across the textual space identify the three 'scenes' in which the actor was to perform. As Newlyn puts it, the writer so carefully confined the Middle Cornish lines to a 'narrow three-inch or palm-width surface ... for ease in memorisation, for use in rehearsal, or perhaps as an aid to memory during performance'.¹⁰⁹

Actors' parts like these offer *prima facie* evidence to establish the relationship between actor and text. The only purpose of an actor's part is to facilitate the actor's preparation for, and memorisation of, his role before the performance. Actors never saw the complete text itself. Parts were copied out of the complete text and distributed to the actors before rehearsals. Actor's parts, as Newlyn suggests, may also serve as an *aide memoire* when carried on stage and held in the hand or hidden up a sleeve. Such a use, of course, also demonstrates that an on-stage director-prompter is not being employed. The actor in possession of a part is expected to rely entirely upon memorizing his role, supplemented perhaps by surreptitiously consulting his actor's part while onstage, to get him through the performance.

As textual evidence, an actor's part from a fourteenth-century interlude does not necessarily tell us much about the preparations actors may have taken to perform a fifteenth- or sixteenth-century *guary-mirkle*. Paula Neuss, however, discovered precisely this evidence. In preparation for her edition of *The Creacion of the World*, she considered that play's relationship to *Origo Mundi*. The pioneering studies of the play had long since noticed that the *Creacion* borrows extensive passages from *Origo Mundi*. The great majority of these lines, she discovered, derive from the speeches of Deus Pater: 'when a speech by God from *Origo Mundi* is repeated in the *Creacion*, lines spoken before and after it tend to be repeated too. This evidence seems to suggest that the compiler of the *Creacion* had access to some of the lines of an actor who had played God in *Origo Mundi*: some of his speeches and cues'. One textual suggestion of this borrowing occurs in God's speech headings in the *Creacion*. These routinely identify him as 'God the Father'. In one instance, however, the manuscript identifies the speaker as 'Deus Pater', which is the character's name in *Origo Mundi*. There are also some lines in the *Creacion* that are spoken by other characters that seem to have been borrowed from *Origo Mundi*. These are often paraphrases of the parallel lines in *Origo Mundi*, but they all 'occur only in the scenes in the *Creacion* similar to those in *Origo Mundi* when God is present'. At the same time, 'there are no echoes in the *Creacion* of

the *Origo Mundi* words in those sections' where God is not present. 'God was not needed for these scenes'.¹¹⁰

This pattern of borrowing mainly only the speeches of *Deus Pater* from *Origo Mundi*, together with some of the lines surrounding these speeches, suggests the likelihood that the *Creacion* may have been compiled with the help of an actor's part, with cues included. Neuss, however, thinks it more probable that the play makes use of a memorial reconstruction by the actor who played God in the *Origo Mundi* and who sometimes remembered, often imperfectly, some other lines as well. Murdoch is not so sure, however; he thinks that a written source for the lines such as a 'single-role cue part' may still be possible, particularly since the singular *Deus Pater* heading in the *Creacion* suggests a written rather than oral source.¹¹¹

For our purposes, we do not have to choose between these alternatives. Whether the source of the borrowed lines is a written actor's part or an actor's part as memorised and written down, we can say that actors' parts in *Origo Mundi* must certainly have been memorised before performance. If that is so, then the other two parts of the *Ordinalia* — *Passio Christi* and *Resurrexio* — would also have been performed in the same way. We can say further that the writer of the *Creacion*, who composes a play around an actor's part, certainly knew what an actor's part was. Probably, therefore, that play too was written to be memorised from parts.¹¹² Two of the four extant *guary-mirkle* texts — the *Ordinalia* and the *Creacion* — thus offer direct evidence that the actors memorised their lines, almost certainly with the help of actors' parts, before performing these plays. Moreover, there is no reason why the other two saints' plays would not also have been performed in this way. There is, however, considerable evidence to suggest that none of these plays could easily have been performed in the way that Carew thinks they were. Indeed, their staging requirements often suggest that such on-stage prompting-directing would have been nearly impossible. The evidence thus overwhelmingly suggests that the ordinary actor, not the Ordinary, was in control of the book, or rather his part of the book, when on stage.

9. A medieval staging convention?

Because 'evaluating Carew's description on the basis of the extant plays seems counterproductive', as Betcher puts it,¹¹³ proponents of Carew's description have understandably avoided engaging with the extant *guary-mirkle* texts. Instead, it has seemed more productive to view 'prompting in full view of the audience' as a 'medieval staging convention'. This tactic

both broadens the significance of the claim — it is no longer to be regarded just an obscure Cornish convention — and makes it unnecessary to defend the specific details of Carew's description. Even if Carew plainly thinks that the Cornish Ordinary's activities are so peculiar that he has to explain them to an English readership, nevertheless the 'convention' can still be described. Carew may think that the Cornish *version* of the onstage prompter is peculiar, but perhaps he would have regarded other versions of the onstage director as quite normal, indeed conventional.

The difficulty with this approach, of course, is that onstage directors are very hard to find. Butterworth has tried to document instances of onstage direction in the medieval and Early Modern period. He has come up with a list of nine such examples. None of them, however, bear examination. We have already considered one of these, the *conveyour*, at some length. We can, I think, dispose of the other eight more briefly.

Let us begin with the four pictorial illustrations that he has found. Butterworth is in good company in thinking that Fouquet's *Martyrdom of St Apollonia* depicts a fifteenth-century French *meneur du jeu* directing a *mystère*. This theory, however, rests on nothing more substantial than a flash of inspiration by the brilliant French scholar, Gustave Cohen, one that simply cannot be substantiated, not even in the production book for the *Mons Passion* — Cohen calls it *le Livre de Conduite du Régisseur* — where he thought he had found traces of his presence. To the contrary, that text provides considerable evidence to rule out such an onstage director, and there is no other documentary evidence for such a *regisseur toujours sur les planches* ('an always-onstage director'), as he calls him, anywhere else in France.¹¹⁴ There is, indeed, good reason to think that Fouquet's image means to illustrate a classical Roman performance, as described by Isidore de Seville, where a poet declaimed the text while actors mimed the action.¹¹⁵

The reappearance of the blue-coated, book-holding figure in Fouquet's *Rape of the Sabine Women* illustrates frequent practice in Fouquet's atelier of reusing figures from an earlier painting in a later one, but otherwise it tells us nothing about the performance of an onstage director. The bookholding figure appears as a tiny figure, recessed into the background where he is not obviously directing anything and stands motionless contemplating an idol atop a column. Far from an illustration of a medieval theatre, as some suggest, the image clearly illustrates a Roman circus; its obvious, deeply-oval shape is required for horse racing, and the

pillar with its idol serves as one of the two *meta* around which the horses turned in the race.

Neither Hubert Cailleau's image of one of the Valenciennes *superintendants* nor the portrait of a fancifully behatted Jakob Ruf are depicted as onstage directors. The Valenciennes *superintendant* carries a small scroll rather than a book. His image is framed by the text of the legal contract that binds actors to obey the *superintendant* and lists penalties for disobeying them. He carries a scroll and staff as symbols of his authority: the scroll in one hand represents the very legal contract that frames his image; it grants him the authority symbolised by his staff, which he grasps in his other hand. Jakob Ruf, by contrast, is clearly a producer and director of plays he has written. His staff almost certainly represents his authority over his subordinates, including actors, and the book unquestionably refers to the text of the play that he is producing and directing. But the several images of Ruf as author-producer never depict him as an onstage director. At the beginning of the play, he sends a herald off to begin the play, while at the end of the play he receives the herald again to close the play. Moreover, these portraits of Ruf and the anonymous Valenciennes *superintendant* never appear in the many illustrations that show hundreds of actors plying their craft onstage. They both remain decidedly offstage presences.

Three other instances of supposed onstage directing collected by Butterworth seem to contradict the existence of such a convention. Two records from Rhetoricians' contests in the Low Countries thus report that the *bouchouwere* (book-holder) was covered and could not be seen.¹¹⁶ Similarly Stephen Gosson's reference to 'this London *Sabinus*' who 'can not playe the Poet without a Prompter; nor vtter a wise worde, without a Piper' tells us nothing at all about the 'convention' of onstage directing. Rather, in sneering at an incompetent writer who cannot recite poetry without a prompter, Gosson implies that writers, like actors, generally do not require prompters; this 'London *Sabinus*', however, is so hopeless that he does.¹¹⁷

The 'Tragedie named Dido', performed before Queen Elizabeth in King's College Chapel, Cambridge (1563), seems at first more promising. Robert Dudley and William Cecil 'to signifye theyre good wille, and that things might be orderlye done, vouchsafed to hold both books on the scaffold themselves, and to provide also that sylence might be kept with quietness'.¹¹⁸ Certainly these two powerful magnates sat on stage in full view of the audience and held books of some kind, but this was not a case of 'seeing but not seeing', as Butterworth characterises the 'convention' of

onstage directing. Cecil and Dudley were not only the most important of Elizabeth's courtiers — Cecil as Secretary of State and Dudley as the Queen's favourite — but they each held important, if largely ceremonial posts, at Oxford: Cecil as Chancellor and Dudley as Steward. They sat on the stage not to direct the play but to secure order and quietness. They are meant to be seen.

Their holding of the books may reflect some anxieties about the play. Like the secretary who sat at the first station of the York plays, they may perhaps have checked that the play does not drift off script into sensitive territory. A month before the performance, Cecil had written to ask the university to 'comunicate any thyinge with me concernying this matter' and asked that 'some man of knoledge ... with whom I may confere' might be sent to him. He closed his letter by warning the university that 'my desyer is that twoe thynges may specyally appeare in that vniueersitie. / Order / and lernyng. And for order I meane bothe for religioun and Civyll behavior'.¹¹⁹ Read in the context of Cecil's letter, the invitation to the University Chancellor and the Steward to sit on stage with the books may have been an exercise in reassurance that nothing would be amiss, that no dangerous religious questions would pop up. However one looks at this record, it cannot be seen as a conventional exercise in on-stage directing; the incident it describes is clearly an exceptional event; university Stewards and Chancellors — particularly when they are also the Queen's Secretary of State and her favourite — do not make a habit of sitting on stage, with or without books in hand.¹²⁰

Butterworth stands on much firmer ground in discussing possible modern examples of the 'convention'. He cites, for instance, several reports of nineteenth-century onstage prompting. In the early nineteenth century, Mme de Staël Holstein ridicules the prompter at Vienna who 'used to furnish most of the actors with every word of their parts'. He even followed 'Othello from one side of the scene to another, to prompt him with the verses which he had to pronounce on poniarding Desdemona'. August Wilhelm von Schlegel seconds this complaint: Italian actors, he reports, 'have no idea that their parts ought to be got by heart, and hence we hear every piece almost twice over in an Italian theatre', once from the prompter, once again from the actor. Auguste Kotzebue similarly complains that German actors require the aid of a prompter, 'without which they cannot proceed for long: they know nothing by heart'.¹²¹ Some of these examples, however, may not be very pertinent. A nineteenth-century writer recalls a rustic stage in Shropshire upon which,

'in full view of the audience sat the chairman with his book, who acted as Prompter and Call Boy in one'. This is not a survival of an ancient convention, however, but a country version of a London music hall, which included a 'chairman' as a sort of master-of-ceremonies.¹²²

Butterworth finds a twentieth-century 'onstage prompter' in Argentina, where 'the short interval between the writing and the production of the play necessitates the use of two prompters, one of whom is stationed in the prompter's box, and the other in the wings'. So short is the production time that 'sometimes the cast will never have read the play they are about to perform, and will hardly know whether it is a comedy or tragedy until after the opening'. The latter of the two prompters 'reads the script a few lines ahead of the cast, who pick up their speeches from him as they go along, with amazing facility'.¹²³ He finds a similar, if electronic, performance technique where 'the actors are fed all their lines by the prompter through an ear piece ... He also tells the actors where to move, how to say the lines and how to respond'. The actors report that it is easy to perform in this way.¹²⁴

An annual performance of a *Representación de Moros y Cristianos* in Trevelez, Spain, provides Butterworth with his most intriguing model for the onstage director. In some respects, he directs the play in much the same way that Carew's Ordinary does: he stands behind the different actors and 'speaks the lines at a volume that can be heard by the performer but not the spectators'. The actors, therefore, 'do not need to know their lines in the first place'. The 'maestro' not only feeds lines to the actors, but he also 'gives emphasis and expression to the line [of actors] in order to create sense and meaning'. A short pause usually occurs 'during which the actor may be seen to listen for his next line and cue'. When he delivers his lines, he 'lifts up his eyes and bodily attitude to repeat it to the audience'. Studying this performance convinced Butterworth that the technique was workable and led directly to his own experimentation with the staging of a performance of a portion of the *Secunda Pastorum* at the Tenth Triennial Colloquium of the Société Internationale pour l'Étude du Théâtre Médiéval at the Rijksuniversiteit, Groningen, Netherlands, in July 2001.¹²⁵

There are some important differences between the Trevelez *maestro* and Carew's Ordinary. Perhaps as a reflection of the relatively brief text, the *maestro* does not need to carry a book but instead feeds lines to his actors from memory. More importantly, the actors 'line up at the front of the platform', so that the *maestro* need only move behind the line, pausing to speak to each actor in turn. Another, more agile prompter located at

ground level has to position himself carefully to be heard by actors mounted on horseback and to avoid being kicked by the horses. Two more prompters — perhaps ‘learning their trade’, Butterworth thinks — carry sheets of paper to prompt ‘the humorous sections at the beginning and end of the event’.¹²⁶

One of the lessons of the Trevelez *Representación* that Butterworth applied in his ‘Groningen Experiment’ was to choose a play in which actors could be grouped closely together so as to make it easier for the Prompter to operate without having to run back and forth between his performers. The *Secunda Pastorum* is an ideal choice in this respect. After the opening scene, in which the shepherds arrive singly, they tend to stay together in a group, except for Mak, who exits and re-enters. It makes prompting in the fashion of the Trevelez *Representación* fairly untroubled. But such a production, once again, also begs the question of how an Ordinary would prompt actors who do not necessarily cluster together in close proximity but move individually between *tenta*, sometimes back and forth between opposite sides of the *plain-an-gwary*. As David Mills puts it: ‘In *Secunda Pastorum* Butterworth chose a play of limited casting ... It would be interesting to see the effect of such prompting among a larger acting group, within a larger acting-area, in a longer play, and more diverse costuming — all factors that might apply on a Cornish round, to which Carew’s account relates’.¹²⁷

One could argue, of course, that adjustments might be made to Carew’s brief anecdote, which may be only a snippet of what may have been widespread and more varied practice. Perhaps, as at Trevelez, multiple prompters stationed themselves around the *plain-an-gwary*. One might stand ready in heaven to prompt important characters like Deus Pater, Jesus, Mary, and the Archangel, who often wait for their cues in towers representing heaven. Another may cover actions on one side of the *plain-an-gwary* while another works the actors on the other side. Even so, however, multiple prompters spread across such a large stage area as a *plain-an-gwary* could be difficult to coordinate. Would we need a prompter to prompt the prompters? The more one adjusts Carew’s anecdote to suit such difficulties, the more yet another question is begged: if such a performance ‘convention’ is to be adopted to circumvent textual demands and staging difficulties, why would the performance texts and staging methods not avoid such difficulties in the first place?

We should also remember that the Trevelez *Representación*, which inspires many of these proposed adjustments to Carew’s account of the

Ordinary, cannot be described as a modern survival of a 'traditional custom', perhaps dating back to the late Middle Ages or the Early Modern period. The text, which first appears in print around 1870, exists in three localised variants that are annually performed at neighbouring villages in Granada: Trevelez, Valor, and Juviles. The Valor and Juviles performances, however, 'do not make use of the same prompting convention used at Trevelez'.¹²⁸ 'Traditional custom' may thus seem to favour the Valor and Juviles performance conventions two to one. The Trevelez performance method may simply declare the maestro's importance as reflected in his absolute mastery of the text. Or perhaps the performance mode developed simply to distinguish Trevelez' play from the others. Surely there must be many possible explanations for what seems to be an eccentric performance mode, even among this small cluster of three villages in Granada.

If we are seeking to establish a 'convention' of onstage directing and prompting, then we have to begin by noting that there is no evidence to support its existence as a medieval or Early Modern convention. If it existed in earlier periods at all, it has left no other traces than Carew's anecdote, which appears not to have been an eye-witness report in the first place and separated by some distance from Carew's source. Nor does the convention suit very well the available Cornish dramatic texts. These show acting patterns across a large stage that seem difficult to manage with an Ordinary providing continuous prompting, and the texts themselves provide evidence that actors memorised their roles from parts. The evidence is solid enough to establish a modern, post-1800 one, however, particularly if we allow the continuous prompting of a performer through an electronic earpiece to count as 'onstage'. A limited convention, it most frequently appears today in the production of *telenovelas* and — it has been whispered — in American presidential debates. Perhaps it also appears in the highly critical nineteenth-century reports from Italy, Germany, and Argentina. But if we use these modern instances to construct a medieval convention, we necessarily find ourselves viewing the events of the past through the experience of the present.

10. An Ordinary suggestion

At this point, it may be the wisest course to say that Carew's report is something of a maggot, a word which I use in its Early Modern meaning as appropriate to an Early Modern writer: a fanciful or eccentric idea that fixes itself in one's mind as in 'Ther's a strange Maggot hath got into their

braines'.¹²⁹ Perhaps we might regard the Cornish Ordinary as nothing more than one of Richard Carew's maggots. But I do not want to dismiss Carew's report entirely. The maggot that infects my brain is the title that Carew gives his director-prompter: the Ordinary. That term is the single most credible item of evidence in Carew's anecdote. If there were not in fact somebody called an Ordinary in charge of at least one *guary-mirkle* somewhere in Cornwall, why would Carew make up such a term? Surely, Carew must have accurately received this term through whatever channel of transmission that the anecdote, however garbled or misunderstood, came to him. For that term to reflect meaningfully his duties and functions, as we have seen above, the Ordinary must have wielded absolute power over those subject to his authority. If there were more than one Ordinary, then there would have been no Ordinary at all; he would have been only one of a number of prompters, at best a *primus inter pares*. Carew tells us, moreover, that he carries 'the booke in his hand', not one of the books or a part of a book. This, too, strikes me as genuine. If we look at his activities from the point of view of the ecclesiastical Ordinary, then our theatrical Ordinary's single-handed control of the play book, just as Carew presents it, becomes even more significant. I would therefore like to propose a way in which we might bring together these implications of the Ordinary's suggestive title with a theatrical tradition that we know did exist in the late medieval and Early Modern period.

We should begin by observing that no one actually believes Carew's description, neither sceptics nor champions of Carew's anecdote. Betcher, as we have seen, finds it 'counterproductive' to compare Carew's anecdote with the extant Cornish plays and prefers to think that the Ordinary must have prompted *enterludes* in general — presumably smaller-scale, even indoor plays — rather than the specific 'kinde of Enterlude' called 'the Guary miracle, in English, a miracle-play' that Carew describes. Butterworth thinks that rehearsals are compatible with the Ordinary's directorial functions so that the actor might understand the lines that the Ordinary would prompt him to deliver at performance.¹³⁰ Carew reports that the Ordinary 'lessoned' the actor 'before-hand' on just one point: 'that he must say after him'. Indeed, the 'merry pranke' only works if the actor has not rehearsed his lines beforehand and the Ordinary continues to believe that the 'pleasant conceyted gentleman' is foolishly mistaking stage directions for lines to be spoken aloud. Likewise, the use of multiple prompters in the Trevelez *Representación* model has suggested to some that the Cornish plays may have been prompted in this way too, even though

Carew tells us that a single Ordinary carrying a single book prompted the actors.

I, too, would propose an adjustment to Carew's description, but a very conservative one that preserves most of its features. I suspect that Carew — or perhaps his source — mistook a rehearsal technique for a performance method. Understanding the anecdote in this way explains its otherwise puzzling features. It explains, for instance, why the Ordinary would accept the offer of a 'pleasant conceyted gentleman' to perform in 'an Actors roome' before a live audience without knowing whether he could act satisfactorily or not. If the episode occurred at a rehearsal rather than a performance, then the Ordinary's decision is no longer puzzling. More importantly, such an adjustment readily explains the single most important and as yet unexplained feature of the entire anecdote: if it describes a performance technique, why did the so-called convention exist in the first place? What did continuous, on-stage prompting achieve that memorizing lines did not?¹³¹ If, however, the anecdote describes a rehearsal technique, then it is clearly aimed at helping the actor learn his lines and perform his role.

We should keep in mind that the decline of the Cornish language may provide an important context for this method of conducting rehearsals. Carew's description of the Ordinary most clearly refers to Cornish *guary-mirkles* produced near the time when he was collecting material for his *Survey*. It does not necessarily refer to all Cornish plays produced over the history of the genre. As Carew points out — and modern research continues to document — the Cornish language was suffering a steep decline in his lifetime: 'the English speach doth still encroche vpon it [*the Cornish language*], and hath driuen the same into the vttermost skirts of the shire' (56f).¹³² This decline necessarily puts considerable stress upon the production of Cornish plays in Carew's era. It is not merely a matter of finding actors who know Cornish well enough to perform roles; even those who could speak Cornish may well not have been literate in that language. Very few books existed — indeed almost none in Carew's time — and interestingly, most of those that have survived are texts of the Cornish plays. At the very least, therefore, some directorial mediation of the text would be necessary for the actors. In the extreme, perhaps, this mediation might take the form of oral memorisation in which the Ordinary would teach the actor his role by reading it to him as he memorised it, much as Nell Gwynn is sometimes said to have learned her lines.

The latest of the Cornish play manuscripts, *The Creacion of the World*, offers evidence of this stress in the amount of English that appears in the play. The stage directions are in English. While God speaks in 'pure Cornish', low characters often speak in English. Devils speak in both tongues, and when repeating what God has said, they sometimes replace a Cornish word with an English one. There are often bilingual puns. Together, these produce, as Bakere observes, 'an effect similar to the high and low style of the English moral plays, where the Latinate diction of the Virtues contrasts with the 'plain-speaking' of the Vices'.¹³³ This slightly bilingual text speaks, of course, to a Cornwall that is becoming increasingly anglicised. It also appeals to actors who are prone to pepper their Cornish with English words and sometimes, even when speaking Cornish, lapse into passages of English.

From the point of view of an Ordinary, control over the text in these conditions is very important. The actors may all speak Cornish in varying degrees, but speaking is not the same thing as reading a Cornish text. How well do they read, understand, and pronounce perhaps unfamiliar Cornish words in a Cornish text, particularly if they are performing a much-less anglicised text written a century or two earlier? Under these conditions, the producer-director of a Cornish *guary-mirkle* would face similar responsibilities with respect to controlling the representation of the theatrical text as does the ecclesiastical ordinary. The latter has to make sure that priests under his authority can read, understand, and preach Holy Scripture accurately. The former, particularly in a time when spoken Cornish was declining, would oversee the actors' competence in reading, pronouncing, and performing the text of the play, that thereby its theological content might not be misrepresented through faulty understanding and acting. There would be good reason to call him 'the Ordinary' and to refer to the texts he was producing and directing as *Ordinalia*. In 1476, the York Councillors established a very similar vetting procedure; in an *Ordinacio pro Ludi Corporis christi*, they determined that three of the 'moste Connyng discrete and able playeres within þis citie' shall henceforth 'examen all þe plaiers' who were to perform in the Corpus Christi Play, 'And all suche as þay shall fynde sufficient in personne and Connyng to þe honour of þe Citie and Worship of þe saide Crafters for to admit' as actors, but 'all oþer insufficient personnes either in Connyng voice or personne to discharge ammove and avoide'.¹³⁴

So far our commentaries on Carew's anecdote have focused on the use of the book supposedly carried by the Ordinary in performance. A more

important question, I would urge, is the use of texts in rehearsal. It strikes me as extraordinary that plays of this length and complexity might not be rehearsed. In preparing his cast for the 'Groningen Experiment', Butterworth gave his actors scripts to read so that they could familiarise themselves with the Middle English text, and he asked them to choose the scenes that would be performed. Ten intensive rehearsal sessions and a preliminary performance then followed.¹³⁵ This procedure was necessary because the student cast was unfamiliar with Middle English. But in rehearsing these texts, as Butterworth chronicles the process, the prompter's repetitions of the lines necessarily increased the actors' familiarity with the text he was reading. Given this familiarity, the actors actually found themselves having to try not to learn their lines, because 'to do so would be to invalidate the role of the prompter and the actors' dependence upon him'. Despite a 'conscious effort on their part', however, 'the actors started to anticipate the lines from the prompter' and 'a familiarity with the lines started to grow'. Moreover, because they did not necessarily understand the Middle English lines they were speaking, 'the time and effort that was to be expended on the need to understand the language of the play inevitably increased familiarity with the lines. This process was necessary, although it did affect the original condition that the actors should not learn lines' (130–31). By the eighth rehearsal, Butterworth reports, 'the actors only needed to be fed two or three words before launching into their lines' (136).¹³⁶ By the end of the rehearsal process, 'overlapping' the remainder of the prompted line became a matter of executed pride' (159). This suggests that, whether one chooses to call it 'familiarity' or memorisation, a good deal of line learning must have occurred in the rehearsal process.

Such an outcome is predictable. Repetition facilitates memorisation, no matter how hard one tries to avoid it. When you add blocking to the rehearsal (which began in Butterworth's production at the fourth rehearsal), the prompt to the memory increases. If you tell an actor, for instance, to say a particular line while crossing stage left, then the association of the two — movement and line — powerfully support one another in the memory. If you find yourself crossing stage left at a particular point in the play, chances are you will remember the line you're supposed to be saying, and vice versa. Even if you never read the lines you are to speak, repetition will probably ensure that you memorise them through aural repetition.

Some modern directors, indeed, have experimented with this technique. In the 1960s, for instance, Robert Sickinger experimented with aural learning of lines at the Hull House Theater in Chicago. I was then a graduate student at the University of Chicago, and like everyone else who cared about theatre in that city, I was transfixed by the performances he staged. I remember asking him why he could get so much out of essentially amateur performers, and he replied that he liked to double-cast his plays. By this he meant that the actor who appeared on stage never read the script. Rather, his actors were taught their lines aurally by their script-doppelgangers who were responsible for reading their parts aloud to them until they had been memorised. This, he thought, made the actors more effective because the lines were memorised from speech rather than from a written script.

With this in mind, perhaps we ought to revisit the nineteenth-century Argentinian example that Butterworth has turned up as an example of continuous prompting. One of the two prompters, we recall, stations himself in the wings and 'reads the script aloud a few lines ahead of the cast, who pick up their speeches from him as they go along, with amazing facility'. This may indeed be an example, as Butterworth thinks, of continuous prompting during performance. But it may instead be a pre-production aural memorisation technique. The writer thus tells us that the use of two prompters was necessary because of 'the short interval between the writing and the production of the play'. In that brief interval, the director may have adopted this technique to help the actors learn their lines. 'Sometimes' we are told, 'a cast will never have read the play they are about to perform and will hardly know whether it is a comedy or a tragedy until after the opening'. But if they do not read the play beforehand only 'sometimes', then sometimes they do read it beforehand. In either case, the use of the offstage, continuous prompter makes a lot of sense if one has to rapidly produce a play because it combines line memorisation with onstage rehearsal. Apparently the audience did not hear the offstage prompter during performance. 'If one did not know the actual conditions beforehand,' we are told, 'he would never suspect them from the performance itself.'¹³⁷ During performance, prompting would be in the hands of the other prompter, who is discreetly positioned in the prompter's box. In considering these modern examples, one wonders whether Butterworth and the Argentinians may have unconsciously recreated something of the rehearsal strategy that Carew's anecdote may describe.

I think it unlikely, however, that the Ordinary would have the time or patience to read lines individually to each actor until they have been memorised. There are just too many actors in a *guary-mirkle* for such intensive, individual attention, particularly since such performances seem to have lasted for two or three days. Besides, as we have seen, we have good evidence that individual actors' parts were used in these Cornish plays so that actors might memorise their lines. If we are to understand how the Ordinary 'lessoned (before-hand)' his actors that they 'must say after him', even as he also distributed actors' parts, we shall have to understand better the ways that Early Modern actors cooperated with directors in rehearsal.

In Carew's era, as Tiffany Stern tells us, 'the emphasis of preparation was on "private" or "individual" rehearsal (also called "study")', during which the actor worked on his or her own "part" for performance'.

Parts were often practised in the presence of an 'instructor' who was either author, prompter, manager, or friend to the actor, and who helped further to prescribe the rules that limited verbal and gestural range ... David Garrick taught Edward Cape Everard by 'reading' him his part with 'Now, sir, say *this* after me;' when Hamlet says 'Speake the speech ... *as I pronounc'd it to you*' ... he actually means just that. Once established, the method of playing was fixed not just for that particular production, but for all subsequent productions. New actors being trained to perform established roles were taught to mimic precisely the manner in which the part has first been acted: rehearsal was only necessary to ensure that the actor had 'correctly' received a part, and young players were harshly judged against their 'originals'.¹³⁸

Players were thus prompted in learning their roles, even as they memorised their lines from their actors' parts. The performance of each actor was carefully controlled to make sure that the speeches were correctly pronounced and the interpretation of each role true to received tradition. We even hear Garrick and Hamlet unconsciously echoing the Ordinary's admonition that the actors 'must say after him'.

In rehearsing *guary-mirkles*, it seems likely that new actors would be asked to begin rehearsal without having memorised their lines beforehand. The Ordinary would want to teach the actor his part by reading it to him and having him repeat the lines after him. If the play were an annual performance or revival of an old play, he would want to train the young

actor to ensure that he had correctly 'received' his part. He would also have to demonstrate how to perform the role at the same time: When you hear your cue, you go onstage and pomp about. When you say this line, descend from your *tentum*. In that way, the Ordinary could assess the actor's ability to understand Cornish and he could better ensure that the delivery and interpretation of the lines would be to his liking. Then he could be given his part to memorise, and thereafter he could be continually monitored and corrected throughout rehearsals to make sure that the performance is precisely what the Ordinary expects.

If the *guary-mirkle* were a traditional fixture, one performed regularly over a period of time, the Ordinary's job of supervision would be considerably easier. If a good number of actors were veterans and performing the same roles they had played before, then they would have their roles already memorised and would need less attention. The Ordinary, as the *conveyour* evidence suggests, may well be a master actor himself, thereby making his authority to tell other actors how to perform their roles even more secure. He is unlikely to have been a cleric untrained and untested in theatrical performance.

Then as now, rehearsals often encourage 'good-humoured banter', as Butterworth calls it when it manifested itself in his own rehearsals (131). One could thus well imagine a 'pleasant conceyted gentleman' offering to undertake 'an Actors roome', and to show his mettle and class superiority, he might well wish to practice 'a merry pranke' on the Ordinary. As the Ordinary begins to teach him his role by reading it to him from the 'booke in his hand', he might well pretend to confuse stage directions with speeches, thus bringing about the practical joke that Carew has recorded. For all we know, however, he went on to perform his role splendidly. Carew, after all, does not tell us that the actor was fired or that he refused to perform his role in the end. But he certainly broke up the rehearsal 'with a great deale more sport and laughter, then 20. such Guaries could haue afforded'.

We cannot know which of these 'conventions' is more correct: the continuous onstage prompter, or the rehearsal strategy. Both depend upon presumed adjustments to Carew's account which cannot be documented. I would suggest, however, that the rehearsal convention is more likely in that we can be sure that it actually existed. By contrast, the existence of an onstage prompter-director convention simply cannot be shown to have existed as a medieval or Early Modern convention. The rehearsal convention also explains almost all of the features of Carew's anecdote,

while the ‘convention’ of the continuous onstage prompter requires many more hypothetical adjustments to make it work. The rehearsal convention works easily with the texts of the four *guary-mirkle* texts that we have, while the other does not. We do not have to overlook or explain away the evidence of actors’ parts that indicate role memorisation. For these reasons, it seems to me that the rehearsal technique convention is the one that we should be exploring to understand Carew’s anecdote.

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NOTES

1. E.K. Chambers *The Mediaeval Stage* 2 vols (London: Oxford UP, 1903) 2 140.
2. Brian O. Murdoch ‘The Cornish Medieval Drama’ in *The Cambridge Companion to Medieval English Theatre* edited Richard Beadle (Cambridge UP, 1994) 215–16.
3. *Records of Early English Drama: Dorset and Cornwall* edited Rosalind Conklin Hays, C.E. McGee, Sally L. Joyce, and Evelyn S. Newlyn (University of Toronto Press, 1999) 402.
4. Glynne Wickham *The Medieval Theatre* (Cambridge UP, 3rd edition 1974) 84. I characterise Wickham’s view of Carew’s accuracy as ‘relatively trustworthy’ because a few pages later, he warns that ‘Richard Carew’s *Survey of Cornwall* was written in 1602, so even his testimony concerning performances in the Cornish ‘Rounds’ has to be received with some caution’ (86).
5. Philip Butterworth ‘Book-Carriers: Medieval and Tudor Staging Conventions’ *Theatre Notebook* 46 (1992) 15–30; Philip Butterworth ‘Jean Fouquet’s “The Martyrdom of St Apollonia” and “The Rape of the Sabine Women” as Iconographical Evidence of Medieval Theatre Practice’ *Leeds Studies in English* NS 29 (1998); Philip Butterworth ‘Prompting in Full View of the Audience: A Medieval Staging Convention’ in *Drama and Community: People and Plays in Medieval Europe* edited Alan Hindley (Turnhout: Brepols, 1999) 231–47; Philip Butterworth ‘Prompting in Full View of the Audience: The Groningen Experiment’ *Medieval English Theatre* 23 (2001) 122–71; Philip Butterworth ‘Richard Carew’s “Ordinary”: The First English Director’ in *The Narrator, the Expositor, and the Prompter in European Medieval Theatre* edited Philip Butterworth (Turnhout: Brepols, 2007) 317–43.
6. Gloria J. Betcher ‘Makers of Heaven on Earth: The Construction of Early Drama in Cornwall’ in *Material Culture & Medieval Drama* edited Clifford Davidson (Kalamazoo, Michigan: Medieval Institute Publications, 1999) 116.

7. Peter Holland 'On the Gravy Train: Shakespeare, Memory and Forgetting' in *Shakespeare, Memory and Performance* edited Peter Holland (Cambridge UP, 2006) 216.
8. Tiffany Stern *Rehearsal from Shakespeare to Sheridan* (Oxford UP, 2000) 94; Simon Palfrey and Tiffany Stern *Shakespeare in Parts* (Oxford UP, 2007) 16.
9. Richard Carew *The Survey of Cornwall* (London: John Jaggard, 1602) 71^v–72^r. Further references to Carew's *Survey* will be cited in text.
10. Butterworth 'Book-Carriers' 15–18; see also substantially the same complaints in Butterworth 'Prompting' 238–9.
11. Betcher 'Makers of Heaven' 103.
12. 'These few notes I haue culled out of many others', he tells us when teasing out the lineage of Sir John Arundel; Carew *Survey* 147^v.
13. I choose these typical examples to illustrate the variety of his assertions of authorial observation: 128^v, 129^v, 141^v, 142^r, 150^v.
14. Carew divides the population of Cornwall into four 'degrees': these 'descend' from the 'nobility and gentlemen' to 'townsmen,' then 'husbandmen,' and finally the 'poore' (63^v–68^r). There are also the 'yeomanrie', but Carew tells us that 'I can say little, worth the obseruing, for any difference from that of other shires, and therefore I will step downe the next staire to husbandmen' (66^r). The 'countrey people' belong to the 'degree' of 'husbandmen.'
15. *Records of Early English Drama: York* edited Alexandra F. Johnston and Margaret Rogerson 2 vols (University of Toronto Press, 1979).
16. A commonplace Latin maxim. A more literal translation might be, 'Let credence be with the author'.
17. *Calendars of the Proceedings in Chancery, in the Reign of Queen Elizabeth; to Which Are Prefixed Examples of Earlier Proceedings in That Court, Namely, from the Reign of Richard the Second to That of Queen Elizabeth, Inclusive. From the Originals in the Tower* edited John Bayley, 3 vols (London: G. Eyre and A. Strahan, 1827–32) 1 267; Sir Edward Coke *The Fourth Part of the Institutes of the Laws of England: Concerning the Jurisdiction of Courts* (London: W. Clarke and Sons, 1817) 230.
18. Butterworth 'Carew's Ordinary' 338, objects to 'some erroneous interpretation' of Carew's remark on the 'grosseness' of the '*Romanes vetus Comedia*'. This does not mean, he thinks, that Carew thought these plays to be 'crude, naive, and untrustworthy', but rather that 'Carew's comment refers to the style of presentation and not to presentational quality of lack of it. The "*Romanes vetus Comedia*", by its nature, was relatively simple in its narrative structure but bold and skilful in its execution. This is the comparison to which Carew alludes'. I find it hard to reconcile these sophisticated qualities with Carew's

perception of 'grossenes', a word that he applies to both the Cornish plays and the Roman *vetus comedia* alike.

19. REED: *Dorset and Cornwall* 402. Betcher ('Makers of Heaven' 103–25) makes much of this possibility.
20. As a notable exception to this observation, Carew twice mentions William Kiltor or Kilter (63^r, 98^r), a Cornish 'husbandsman', whose crime made him notorious enough for his name to be significant. Carew thinks he 'occasioned' the Cornish rebellion of 1549 with the murder of William Bodye. (See Carew's account of this sensational political murder cited below.) For Kilter, see George Clement Boase and William Prideaux Courtney *Bibliotheca Cornubiensis. A Catalogue of the Writings, Both Manuscript and Printed, of Cornishmen, and of Works Relating to the County of Cornwall, With Biographical Memoranda and Copious Literary References. Volume 3* (London: Longmans, Green, Reader and Dyer, 1882) 1260.
21. Shakespeare *A Midsummer Night's Dream* 3.1.88–98. See Palfrey and Stern *Shakespeare in Parts* 157, on Flute's comic misunderstanding of the function of the actor's 'part', which includes only the text of his own role and his cues.
22. J.P.D. Cooper *Propaganda and the Tudor State: Political Culture in the Westcountry* (Oxford Historical Monographs; Oxford: Clarendon Press, 2003) 202. Matthew Spriggs 'Where Cornish Was Spoken and Where: A Provisional Synthesis' in *Cornish Studies Second Series 11* edited Philip Payton (Exeter: University of Exeter Press, 2003) 239–45, provides a fresh view of the decline of Cornish as English progressively replaced it from East to West in the County. See particularly illustrations 2 through 6 that map the areas of where Cornish was spoken between 1200 to 1799.
23. Jane A. Bakere *The Cornish Ordinalia: A Critical Study* (Cardiff: University of Wales Press, 1980) 13, likewise points out that 'even if Carew were himself a spectator, his limited knowledge of Cornish as revealed in the *Survey* makes it doubtful how much he would have understood of what was happening'. She draws attention as well to 'Nance's comment on Carew's Cornish in the Nance MSS at the Royal Institution [of] Cornwall, Truro' in support of her characterisation of Carew's limited knowledge of Cornish (174 note 25), but I have not been able to consult this source.
24. Cranmer was quick to point out the illogic of this demand: 'I would gladly know the reason why the Cornish men refuse utterly the new English, as you call it, because certain of you understand it not; and yet you will have the service in Latin, which almost none of you understand. If this be a sufficient cause for Cornwall to refuse the English service because some of you understand none English, a much greater cause have they, both of Cornwall and Devonshire to refuse utterly the late service; forasmuch as fewer of them know the Latin tongue than they of Cornwall the English tongue': Cooper

- Propaganda* 64; Frances Rose-Troup *The Western Rebellion of 1549: An Account of the Insurrections in Devonshire and Cornwall Against Religious Innovations in the Reign of Edward VI* (London: Smith, Elder, 1913) 493 and appendix G.
25. Cooper *Propaganda* 64. See also Jon Mills 'Genocide and Ethnocide: The Suppression of the Cornish Language' in *Interfaces in Language* edited John Partridge (Newcastle: Cambridge Scholars, 2010) 189–206 at 199–200: 'Following the Prayer Book Rebellion, the Cornish language was to become stigmatised as a "backward" language, and the language of Catholics potentially allied to enemies of England ... The Cornish language was thus largely abandoned by the Cornish gentry'. In the late-seventeenth century, William Scawen, an early Cornish language revivalist, made essentially this same point, that the Cornish gentry's abandonment of the language was one of the chief 'causes of the Cornish speech's decay': *The Parochial History of Cornwall* 4, *Observations on an Ancient Manuscript, Entitled Passio Christi, Written in the Cornish Language, and Now Preserved in the Bodleian Library; with an Account of the Language, Manners, and Customs of the People of Cornwall* edited Davies Gilbert, 4 vols (London: J. B. Nichols and Son, 1838) 214–15.
 26. Richard calls Sir Peter Carew 'the eldest of our stock (a Gentleman, whose rare worth my pen is not able to shaddow, much lesse with his due lineaments to represent)' (102^v). For the activities of Sir Peter and Gawain Carew in suppressing the Western Rising, see W.K. Jordan *Edward VI, The Young King: The Protectorship of the Duke of Somerset* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard UP, 1968) 460–74.
 27. According to F.E. Halliday, editor of *Richard Carew of Antony: The Survey of Cornwall &c* (London: Andrew Melrose, 1953) 126 note 1, Carew has failed to understand the full implications of this sentence: *My ny-vynnaf cows sawsneck* means 'I will not speak English', not 'I cannot speak English'.
 28. The rhymes are:
Tru ru,
Triueth eu,
Ombdina geueth try ru.
 'Which is to say, Truro consisteth of three streetes, and it shall
 in time bee said, Here Truro stood' (141^v–2^r).
Ewra teyre a war meane Merlyn
Ara Lesky Pawle Pensanz ha Newlyn (158^v–9^r)
 This ancient prophecy, which has long 'run amonst them', Carew tells us, portends 'how there should land vpon the rock of Merlin, those that would burn Pauls Church, Pensants, and Newlyn'.

29. Spriggs 'Where Cornish Was Spoken' (38–9) thinks that while this statement 'may possibly have been true in the west of Cornwall at this time', it was 'most unlikely to have been the case for easternmost Cornwall' in Carew's lifetime.
30. The Cornish word is also spelled variously as *celma* and *colma*. Robert Williams *Lexicon Cornu-Britannicum: A Dictionary of the Ancient Celtic Language of Cornwall* (Llandovery and London: Roderic and Trübner, 1865), svv *celma* and *colma*, cites numerous examples from the *Ordinalia*, such as: *ov dyw-luef colm ha'm garrow | gans louan fast colmennow | na allan seuel am saf* ('Tie my hands and my legs | With a rope, fast knots, | That I may not stand up'). See *The Ancient Cornish Drama* edited Edwin Norris, 2 vols (New York: Benjamin Bloom, 1968 reprint of Oxford UP 1859 edition) 102–103 lines 1345–7.
31. Halliday *Richard Carew* 126 note 1. See also note 24 above.
32. I do not pretend to know Cornish; I take my grammatical information from Edwin Norris *Sketch of Cornish Grammar* (Oxford UP, 1859) 41–5, and I realise that this pioneering work may be outdated.
33. Halliday *Richard Carew* 303–308; he repeats in this essay again (307) that Cornish lacks a word for 'tye'.
34. Butterworth 'Prompting' 239; Halliday *Richard Carew* 69–70.
35. His *Godfrey of Bulloigne, or, The recoverie of Hierusalem* is a version of Tasso's *Gerusalemme liberata*; his *Examination of Men's Wits* is a translation of Camillo Camilli's Italian version of Juan Huarte's *Examen de ingenios*; his *World of Wonders* is an adaptation of Henri Estienne's *Apologie pour Herodote*. See S. Mendyk 'Carew, Richard' in *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography* <<http://www.oxforddnb.com/view/article/4635?docPos=1>> (2004–2008).
36. *The Survey of Cornwall by Richard Carew* edited John Chynoweth, Nicholas Orme, and Alexandra Walsham (Exeter: Devon and Cornwall Record Society, 2004) 5.
37. *Alumni Oxonienses: The Members of the University of Oxford, 1500–1714: Parentage, Birthplace, and Year of Birth, With a Record of Their Degrees, Being The Matriculation Register of the University* edited Joseph Foster, 4 vols (Oxford: Parker, 1891–1892) 2 873. For Kennall's role in the entertainments for Queen Elizabeth, see *Records of Early English Drama: Oxford* edited John R. Elliott, Alan H. Nelson, Alexandra F. Johnston, and Diana Wyatt, 2 vols (Toronto and London: University of Toronto Press and The British Library, 2004) 1 126–35, 2 875–79. In describing him as 'Doctor Kennall the Ciuilian', Carew means that he was a Doctor of Civil Law.
38. Carew mentions him twice in the *Survey*. In addition to eulogizing him as representing the 'principall loue and knowledge of this language' (56^v), he mentions Kennall's name again as one of the 'Diuiues' who in Cornwall 'hath been bred or harboured' and 'graced with the degree of Doctorship'. In this

- category, he tells us that 'In the Ciuil law there liued of late Doctor Kennalls, & now doth Doctor *Carew*, one of the ancientest masters of the Chauncerie' (59^v). In both instances, the reference to Kennall is plainly elegiac.
39. Camden mentions that the *Survey* was underway by 1586, although Carew mentions in his dedication to Sir Walter Raleigh that it had 'been long since begun' and 'a great while discontinued' before being 'lately reuiewe, and now hastily finished' (sig ¶ 3r). The beginnings of the work thus lie outside of Carew's time at Christ Church and after Kennall's death. For these reasons, perhaps Carew could not consult Kennall. See also Chynoweth, Orme, and Walsham *The Survey of Cornwall by Richard Carew* 3.
 40. *Alumni Oxonienses* 4 (1645); Anthony à Wood *Athenæ Oxonienses: An Exact History of All the Writers and Bishops Who Have Had Their Education in the University of Oxford* edited Philip Bliss (London: F.C. and J. Rivington and others, 3rd edition 1813) 1 703–704; J.E. Caerwyn Williams 'Williems [Williams], Thomas' in *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography* <<http://www.oxforddnb.com/view/article/29549?docPos=1>>; William David Williams 'Wiliems, Thomas' in *Welsh Biography Online* <<http://wbo.llgc.org.uk/en/s-WILI-THO-1545.html?query=Wiliems&field=name>> (2009). The Williams who took his BA in 1567 and MA in 1573 is the only Thomas Williams listed in the *Alumni Oxonienses* who could have been at Oxford at the same time as Carew. Most boys matriculated at Oxford between the ages of 16 and 18 (Carew's matriculation at the age of 11 was unusual, but not unprecedented). If Williams was typical in this regard, he would have thus arrived between 1561 and 1564, a few years before Carew's arrival in 1566.
 41. Williams 'Wiliems, Thomas': 'Writing in 1620, he [Williems] says that it took him fifty years to amass the material for the dictionary and four years to write it'. This places the beginnings of Williems' great project at about 1566, precisely at the time Carew was arriving in Oxford. As Williams, 'Williems [Williams], Thomas', points out, however, the date on the title page of his three MS volumes is 1608, so that Wiliems may perhaps have begun his work on the dictionary even earlier. Although in the beginning he collected material in no special order, he eventually took Thomas's *Latin-English Dictionary* (1587) for his model and substituted Welsh equivalents for Thomas's English words.
 42. Mendyk 'Carew, Richard', observes that Carew was 'greatly interested in language, and particularly in etymology'.
 43. *REED: Dorset and Cornwall* 401–408. For the various forms of *Guary* (either as noun, *a play*, or as verb *to play*), see Williams *Lexicon Cornu-Britannicum* sv *Guare*, and William Pryce *Archæologia Cornu-Britannica*; or, *An Essay to Preserve the Ancient Cornish Language; Containing the Rudiments of That Dialect, in a Cornish Grammar and Cornish-English Vocabulary, Compiled From a Variety of*

Materials Which Have Been Inaccessible to All Other Authors (Sherborne: W. Cruttwell, 1790) sv *Guare*.

44. In Fortescue Hitchens *The History of Cornwall from the Earliest Records and Traditions to the Present Time* edited Samuel Drew, 2 vols (1824) 1 69, the author points out that Carew's expression, 'miraculous play or enterlude', is 'a corruption of *guari mirkl*'.
45. E.K. Chambers took *miraculum* to be 'a mere convenient shorthand for *repraesentatio miraculi*', and 'came, especially in England, to stand for "religious play" in general'. He therefore specifically includes all of the religious pageant sequences in this category (e.g. York, Chester, Towneley, *Ludus Coventriae*, Coventry, Newcastle, Norwich) as well as vernacular biblical plays (e.g. the Croxton *Play of the Sacrament*, *Mary Magdalen*, the Brome *Abraham and Isaac*, *The Conversion of St Paul*) and the Cornish Plays; Chambers *Mediaeval Stage* 2 104, 407–436. This definition profoundly influenced such later scholars as Glynne Wickham, who entitles his chapter on vernacular religious plays 'Miracle Plays', and refers to the religious pageant sequences as 'Miracle Cycles': Glynne Wickham *Early English Stages 1300 to 1660, Volume One: 1300 to 1576* (London: Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1959) 112–76. The use of the term 'Miracle Play' in this inclusive way relies heavily upon the Wycliffite *Tretise of Miraclis Pleyinge* and a very few other mainly fifteenth-century texts. Clifford Davidson observes that 'if there were a "precise" meaning of the term "miraculis", however, it was not used in the *Tretise* in any exact way but instead seems to have been intended as a broad category that would link the word "miraculis" with a spectrum of dramatic activity ranging from the staging of religious scenes to representations on feast days and seasons such as Christmas'. He points out, however, that 'at no point in the treatise are the great civic Corpus Christi cycles mentioned' even though 'such dramatic spectacles were already in existence by the late fourteenth century': *A Tretise of Miraclis Pleyinge* edited Clifford Davidson (EDAM Monograph Series 19; Kalamazoo, Michigan: Medieval Institute Publications, 1993) 2. In addition, 'clerk plays' were called *miracula*. These were 'written, directed, and probably performed by members of the minor clergy, possibly in the churchyard, market-place, or outside the city walls rather than in the church'. These are almost certainly one of the targets of the *Tretise*. Lawrence M. Clopper would limit the *Tretise's* attack principally to such *miracula*, which he construes as 'clerical parodies and *irrisiones*' that largely consisted of 'tricks intended to delight and amuse people and that, in many case, led people to devalue the truth of God's miracles'. Such *miracula*, he thinks, died out in the 1530s about the time of the suppression of the monasteries. Clopper provides a helpful appendix listing all the references he can find to 'Miracula, Miracles, and Steracles in Medieval and Early Modern England' in his *Drama, Play, and Game: English Festive Culture in the Medieval and Early Modern Period* (Chicago and London: University of Chicago Press,

- 2001) 106, 295–8. The appendix makes clear that Carew's use of the term 'Miracle Play' is a singular one. Only in Manning's *Handlyng Synne* ('swych pleyys ... as myracles and bourdys,' c. 1300), the *Tretis of Miracles Pleyinge*, and the Wife of Bath's reference to 'plays of myracles' (Chaucer *Canterbury Tales* D 555–8) do we find terminology that even distantly approximates Carew. One might thus say that Crew unwittingly invented the Miracle Play as a genre. This singularity is further illustrated in the *OED*, where Crew is listed as the first use of the term *Miracle Play*. Thereafter, the next reference to 'theatrical pieces called "Miracles"' occurs in 1798 (*Miracle Play* and *Miracle* sb 2 b), and it then is widely taken up by nineteenth-century historians.
46. Joyce and Newlyn point out that 'an existing place name in Sancreed, "Plain Gwarry", further attests the presence in early times of a plain-an-gwary at that location': *REED: Dorset and Cornwall* 402.
47. See *REED: Dorset and Cornwall* 398, 402, 520.
48. Scawen, the 'father of the Cornish revival', did not speak Cornish. He had John Keigwin translate the manuscript (now London, British Library MS Harley 1782) of the Cornish *Passion of Our Lord*, and he based what he knew of Cornish literature on that translation. In 1695, Edmund Gibson included an abbreviated version of Scawen's passage (though he does not name the source of his borrowing) among the 'Additions to Cornwall' to his new edition of Camden: see *Camden's Britannia, Newly Translated Into English; With Large Additions and Improvements* edited Edmund Gibson (London: F. Collins, 1695) 16. The scholar Edward Lhuyd, a friend of Gibson, agreed to provide Welsh material for the new translation. In 1700, however, Lhuyd was in Cornwall gathering Cornish material for an ambitious new project, the *Archæologia Britannica*, which aimed at a comprehensive study of the languages, natural histories, and cultures of all 'Celtic' peoples of Britain, Ireland, and Brittany. His own manuscript glossary of Cornish words, compiled at this time, records *guary-mirkl* as the Cornish term for Cornish plays, but not *girimiri*. See Geirlyer *Kyrnweig*, Aberystwyth: National Library of Wales MS Llanstephan 84, page 81 (<http://digidol.llgc.org.uk/METS/LAN00001/physical?div=85&subdiv=0&locale=en&mode=reference>). He did not live to publish this glossary, but some of the words found their way into Edward Lhuyd *Archæologia Britannica, Giving Some Account Additional to What Has Been Hitherto Publish'd, of the Languages, Histories and Customs Of the Original Inhabitants of Great Britain; from Collections and Observations in Travels Through Wales, Cornwal, Bas-Bretagne, Ireland, and Scotland, Volume I: Glossography* (Oxford: printed at the Theater for the Author, 1707) 49. See also Pryce *Archæologia Cornu-Britannica* sv. *Guare*; Williams *Lexicon Cornu-Britannicum* sv *Guare*. These draw upon Lhuyd and add further clarifications.

Lhuyd understandably referred to Gibson's translation/expansion of Camden in the course of his researches in Cornwall. In November, 1700, on

the eve of his leaving Cornwall for Brittany, he wrote a letter to his friend, Bishop Nicholson, that records his specific rejection of Scawen's *guirimirs* as reported in Gibson's *Camden*. A few days later, Nicholson wrote to his friend, Dr Chartlet, in part to report on the contents of Lhuyd's letter: 'The Cornish language, he [Lluyd] complains, is so extreamey corrupted with English, that 'tis almost wholly perished. He has transcribed the only (two or three) books that are written in it; and has formed such a vocabulary out of 'em as he had formerly done out of the Irish and Highland Scotch. These books are the *Guirimir*, mentioned in the late edition of *Cambden* [sic]. He supposes that word to be a corruption of *Gwari Mirkkl*; which, in their dialect, signifies a miraculous play or interlude' (William Nicholson 'Part of a letter from Bishop Nicholson to the Rev. Dr. Charlet, Master of University-College Oxford' in Nicholas Owen *British Remains: Or, A Collection of Antiquities Relating to the Britons* (London: J. Bew, 1777) 181-2. Pryce in *Archæologia Cornu-Britannica* flatly asserts that '*guary-meers* signify *great plays* ... but the right name for the interludes is *guare-mirkkl*'. The word is thus a combination of *guary* ('play') and *mer* ('great, big, large') as in Williams *Lexicon Cornu-Britannicum* 252. The error lives on, however, to mislead modern scholars. See for instance Butterworth 'Carew's "Ordinary"' 337-8.

49. I cite these plays from following editions: *Beunans Meriasek: The Life of St Meriasek, Bishop and Confessor, A Cornish Drama* edited Whitley Stokes (London: Trübner, 1872); *Beunans Ke: The Life of St Kea, A Critical Edition with Translation* edited Graham Thomas and Nicholas Williams (University of Exeter Press, 2007); and *The Creacion of the World: A Critical Edition and Translation* edited Paula Neuss (Garland Medieval Texts; New York: Garland, 1983). Line references to these plays will be cited in text.
50. REED: *Dorset and Cornwall* 549-54.
51. Bakere *Cornish Ordinalia* 155-6; Murdoch 'Cornish Medieval Drama' 214-15.
52. Bakere *Cornish Ordinalia* 55.
53. Murdoch 'Cornish Medieval Drama' 214-16.
54. Carew was born on July 17, 1555, and in the *Survey* he tells us that he went to Oxford when he was eleven (102^v). This fixes the date of his matriculation at Christ Church as 1566. That September, Queen Elizabeth was entertained in Christ Church Hall by performances of two Latin plays (*Marcus Geminus*, by Tobie Matthew of Christ Church and *Progne* by James Calhill, Doctor of Christ Church) and one English play (*Palamon and Arcite* in two parts, by Richard Edwards, Master of the Children of the Queen's Chapel). Carew's cousins were very much in evidence. George Carew, former dean of Christ Church (1559-1561) and current Dean and Canon of Windsor, used the occasion to present his son, Peter, to the Queen. Peter 'made an oracion' to the Queen 'in lattyn with ij greeke verses in ye ende which ye Quene lyked so well

- yat shee sente for master Secretarye & wyllled ye boye to pronownce yt agayne ye seconde tyme': *REED: Oxford* 1 130. For a contemporary description of Edwards' *Palamon and Arcite*, see also 1 131–3.
55. Stern *Rehearsal* 96–97. She references Nathaniel Woods' *Conflict of Conscience* (1581) and Lewis Machin's *Every Woman in her Humour* (1609).
 56. But not *director*; according to the *OED* (svv *direct* 5c and *director* 1g), that meaning originated in the United States in the early twentieth century.
 57. Chambers *Mediaeval Stage* 2 140; Wickham *Medieval Theatre* 84.
 58. Butterworth 'Book-Carriers' 23.
 59. Robert Longworth *The Cornish Ordinalia: Religion and Dramaturgy* (Cambridge, Mass: Harvard UP, 1967) 105.
 60. Play One: *Hic incipit Ordinale de Origine mundi*; Play Three: *Hic incipit ordinale de resurrexione domini nostri ihesu xpi*: Oxford: Bodleian Library, MS Bodley 791 fols 1r, 57r.
 61. For this material, I draw mainly upon A. Boudinhon 'Ordinary' in *The Catholic Encyclopedia* 11 (New York: Robert Appleton Company, 1911), but also M.J. Keene 'Ordinaries, Ecclesiastical' in *New Catholic Encyclopedia* 10 (2nd edition 2003) 633–4; *MED* sv *Ordinarie* a; and *OED* sv *Ordinary* 4a, 5. In the *Survey*, Carew mentions *Ordinary* in this sense: 'they again had their Ordinary, the Bishop, euery 3. yere to ouerlook their actions' (82r). He also uses the word in a more playful and secular sense: 'Sermon ended, the Preachers resorted to one ordinary [e.g. a pub, *OED* sv *Ordinary* 12 c] and the Gentlemen to another' (112v).
 62. Katherine Zieman *Singing the New Song: Literacy and Liturgy in Late Medieval England* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2008) 59–60.
 63. Nicholas Watson 'Censorship and Cultural Change in Late-Medieval England: Vernacular Theology, the Oxford Translation Debate, and Arundel's Constitutions of 1400' *Speculum* 70 (1995) 822–64 at 825–7, especially notes 14–15.
 64. Watson 'Censorship' 829–36.
 65. For a succinct account of the events leading up to Archbishop Grindal's attempt to ban the Chester plays in 1572, see David Mills *Recycling the Cycle: Chester and Its Whitsun Plays* (University of Toronto Press, 1998) 145–52. For the unsuccessful attempts of the York Council to gain permission from Archbishop Sandys to perform the sequence in 1579 and 1580, see *REED: York* 1 390, 392–3.
 66. For a discussion of these titles, see Gordon Kipling 'Le Régisseur Toujours sur les Planches: Gustave Cohen's Construction of the Medieval "meneur de Jeu"' *Medieval English Theatre* 28 (2006), 29–130.

67. *Regent* is usually translated as 'director' in English-language studies of the Lucerne Passion Play, but this is perhaps a little misleading. Given his overall control of the production and staging, he was properly the production's *regent*, not simply its director. In addition to Cysat, Martin Banham in *Cambridge Guide to Theatre* (Cambridge UP, 1995) 706, lists the following *regents* and *regens ludi* from German-speaking areas: Benedikt Debs (Bozen); Vigil Raber (Sterzing); and Cysat's predecessors at Lucerne, Hans Salat and Zacharias Bletz.
68. A good idea of Cysat's many responsibilities can be gleaned from the references to Cysat in *The Staging of Religious Drama in Europe in the Later Middle Ages: Texts and Documents in English Translation* edited Peter Meredith and John E. Tailby (Kalamazoo, Michigan: Medieval Institute Publications, Western Michigan University, 1983).
69. For Ruf's biography, see *Jakob Ruf. Leben, Werk und Studien: Mit der Arbeit Seiner Hände: Leben und Werk Des Zürcher Stadtchirurgen und Theatermarchers Jakob Ruf (1501–1558)* edited Hildegard Elisabeth Keller, 5 vols (Zurich: Verlag Neue Zürcher Zeitung, 2008) 1 35–198. Ruf was a proud man, and he liked to flaunt his titles, particularly *Stadtchirugen* of Zurich. Stefan Schöbi, who contributes an excellent chapter to this fine collection, thinks that Ruf bore the honorific title, *Ludius* (155–71). There is no record of Ruf using this title, or of any other person describing Ruf as such. That term, which is a Latin word meaning 'performer', occurs in a cast list for Ruf's play, *Von des herren weingarten* (1539). Because it is the first name in the cast list (followed by *Heroldt*, *Vatter*, *Sun*, *Moses* ...) the term has been thought to refer to Ruf himself, who appears in an illustration sending the Herald on stage to declaim a prologue to the play. It most likely refers, however, to the *Junger Knab* (young fellow) who is the first person to take the stage and deliver a speech preceding the Herald. The *Junger Knab*, moreover, is given an illustration before the one featuring Ruf and the Herald, and he is nowhere else mentioned in the cast list, and as he bears no personal name, *ludius* describes him accurately as an anonymous performer.
70. *Records of Early English Drama: Coventry* edited R.W. Ingram (University of Toronto Press, 1981) 27. Butterworth observes that none of the responsibilities enumerated in this record 'refer to his influence over what the players did or the way they did it. Colclow's duties were concerned with promotion, protection, and preservation of the physical accoutrements belonging to the pageant and the Guild. He was both producer and custodian', he thinks, but he was not a director; Butterworth 'Carew's Ordinary' 340. Perhaps this is so, but the record only describes those duties relevant to the purpose of financial accounting for his stewardship over the materials belonging to the pageant to the Smiths. The account also mentions that he is to 'find þe pleyers', which suggests that his duties may also have extended to direction. It is unwise to draw too exclusive a distinction between directors and producers in this period.

- Often, the same person was responsible for both of those activities. The distinction between these two roles is perhaps more modern than medieval.
71. Meredith and Tailby *Staging* 43–5; for the original contract in full, see Louis Petit de Julleville *Histoire Du Théâtre en France: Les Mystères* 2 vols (Paris: Hachette, 1880) 2 149–52.
 72. Oxford: Bodleian Library, MS Bodley 219, fols 5^r, 5^v, and Paula Neuss *The Creacion of the World: A Critical Edition and Translation* (New York: Garland, 1983) 28, 32, sd at line 343, sd at line 392: Butterworth ‘Book-Carriers’ 31 note 31, correctly points out that Neuss mistranscribes *thei* as *then* in the first of these stage directions.
 73. For a concise summary of the major scholarly literature on the Cornish *conveyour*, see Butterworth ‘Book-Carriers’ 22–4. R. Morton Nance ‘The Plen an Gwary or Cornish Playing Place’ *Journal of the Royal Institution of Cornwall* 24 (1935) 203–205, proposes that the *conveyour* was not a person at all, but rather a kind of subterranean secret passage, specifically the hollowed-out feature known as the ‘Devil’s Spoon’ in Piran Round. Neuss *Creacion* lxvi conclusively dismisses this surmise.
 74. Neuss *Creacion* lxvii; Paula Neuss ‘The Staging of the “Creacion of the World”’ *Theatre Notebook* 33 (1979) 116–25 at 123; Butterworth ‘Book-Carriers’ 23; Henry Hudson’s appointment at York: *REED: York* 1 138; Whatman and Aunderson at New Romney: *REED: Kent: Diocese of Canterbury* edited James M. Gibson, 3 vols (London and Toronto: British Library and University of Toronto Press, 2002) 794.
 75. Robert Hewyk, parish clerk of Leeds, and his two assistants were hired *de & super educcionem ludi Corporis christi videlicet pagine vocate domysday* (‘about and concerning the production of a Corpus Christi play, to wit, of the pageant called Doomsday’); *REED: York* 1 87, 764.
 76. Neuss *Creacion* lv describes this scenic *locus* as ‘less elaborate than Heaven and hell, though it was *fyne*lye made, as the direction at 350 shows, and it contained, besides the two trees, *a fowntayne ... and fyne flowres in yt paynted* (sd at line 359). It must have been quite large, for in the Fall scene it contained both Eve and the serpent, and Adam some distance away’.
 77. Yvette Le Hir ‘Les Indications Scéniques dans le *Mystère de St Etienne* de Nicolas Loupvent’ *Bibliothèque d’humanisme et Renaissance* 42 (1980) 661–76 at 664 and 666. For fuller discussion of these and other similar stage directions, see Kipling ‘*Régisseur*’ 90–94.
 78. Chantilly: Musée Condé, MS 616: edited Xavier Leroux ‘Edition critique et commentaire du *Mistère de la Conception*’ (unpublished dissertation, University of Paris IV–Sorbonne, 2003) lines 7956–63 and sd. Compare the real ceremonial vessels borne processionally in the *Play of Daniel*. For fuller

- discussion of this stage direction and other similar ones in the same play, see Kipling 'Régisseur' 94–104.
79. Butterworth 'Groningen' 126.
 80. Neuss 'Staging' 123; Neuss *Creacion* lxvii–lxviii. Butterworth 'Book-Carriers' 23 accepts Neuss' demonstration that the *conveyour* also is an actor in the role of God, but he does not see that the stage direction refers only to the role of God, not to the *conveyour*'s supposed 'stage management/direction function'. The confusion, perhaps, arises because the first of these two directions does refer to the *conveyour*'s stage-management function, but not to his acting function, while the second refers to his acting function but not his stage-management function.
 81. As Paula Neuss points out, the Creation of Eve appears in panel 5 of the *Creation Window* (early sixteenth-century) in St Neot's Church, Cornwall: Neuss, *Creacion* 214, note to sd at line 392. 'The Creation of Eve' frequently occurs as the second image in the *Speculum humanae salvationis*, to illustrate *Deus creavit hominem ad ymaginem et similitudinem suam* ('God created man in his own image and likeness'). The scene immediately follows The Fall of Lucifer. The opening scenes of the *Creacion of the World* follow closely the first several images in the *Speculum*. See Adrian Wilson and Joyce Lancaster Wilson *A Medieval Mirror: Speculum Humanae Salvationis, 1324–1500* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1984) 29, 62, 75, 142, 209. Can the play perhaps be using the *Speculum* as an outline?
 82. Butterworth 'Book-Carriers: Medieval and Tudor Staging Conventions' 24.
 83. Elie Konigson *La Représentation d'un Mystère de la Passion à Valenciennes en 1547* (Paris: Centre National de la Recherche Scientifique, 1969) 17–19; *The Medieval European Stage, 500–1550* edited Tydeman; *Theatre in Europe: A Documentary History* edited William Tydeman (Cambridge UP, 2001) 546–50.
 84. Tydeman *Medieval European Stage* 338.
 85. Neuss *Creacion* lxviii.
 86. Butterworth 'Book-Carriers' 24.
 87. Butterworth 'Carew's Ordinary' 328.
 88. Butterworth 'Carew's Ordinary' 328, 337.
 89. Betcher 'Makers of Heaven' 116; for John Clarke and the St Ives record, see *REED: Dorset and Cornwall* 399, 515.
 90. For the classic modern definition of the Tudor *interlude* see Wickham *The Medieval Theatre* 169–75. See also T.W. Craik *The Tudor Interlude: Stage, Costume, and Acting* (Leicester UP, 1958) 9: 'indoor performance was, I think, the kind of performance for which most Tudor interludes were designed'.
 91. Clopper *Drama, Play, and Game* 17.

92. Chambers *Mediaeval Stage* 2 181–4. See also James M. Gibson “Interludum Passionis Domini”: Parish Drama in Medieval New Romney’ in *English Parish Drama* edited Alexandra F. Johnston and Wim Hüsken (Amsterdam and Atlanta: Rodopi, 1996) 137–48, for a reconstruction of the New Romney *Passion*.
93. Nick Davis ‘Allusions to Medieval Drama in Britain (4): Interludes’ *Medieval English Theatre* 6:1 (1984) 61. For Eliot, see Sir Thomas Eliot *The Dictionary of Sir Thomas Eliot* (London: Thomas Berthelet, 1538) svv *Comoedia*, *Tragoedia*, and *Ludicrum*; see also Davis 75, for a full list of Eliot’s uses of *enterlude*.
94. Sir Philip Sidney *A Defence of Poetry* in *Miscellaneous Prose of Sir Philip Sidney* edited Katherine Duncan-Jones and Jan van Dorsten (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1973) 94.
95. Because the *Ordinalia* contains three plays — *Origo Mundi*, *Passio Christi*, and *Resurrexio* — the extant corpus of Cornish drama consists of a total of six substantial plays.
96. The stage directions refer to such a structure as a *pulpitum* or *tentum*. *Pulpitum* is a common Latin term for a raised platform; *tentum* suggests fabric construction, including curtains that can be closed. See Bakere *Cornish Ordinalia* 155–6, on this point. In *Bewnans Ke* (lines 394–428), the saint is confined in a prison on the level of the *platea* and probably beneath the *tentum* of the tyrant, Teudar. In the *Ordinalia* (sd at line 2370), King David is buried beneath one of the platforms (*sub aliquo tento*) that surround the *platea*.
97. *Bewnans Ke*: *Lowena thys, Syr Tuthar, | abvarth y’th towr!* (‘Hail to you, Sir Teudar, within your tower!’) lines 70–71; compare similar references to Arthur’s tower, lines 1573, 1683, 1916, 3294. In the *Ordinalia*, King David’s station is described as a *tour* (tower) (lines 2030, 2110, 2389).
98. For the structures of the *loci* representing Heaven and Hell, see Neuss *Creacion* lii–lv.
99. The *Creacion* includes several scenes in which The Father in Heaven, apparently atop his two-or three-storey pageant, carries on conversations with characters in the *platea*. In the *playne*, for instance, Enoch prays to the ‘maker of heaven’ that ‘I may always have the pleasure | to be his [God’s] servant | unfailingly in this world | as long as I live.’ Enoch drops to his knees in surprise as the Father immediately responds from his celestial tower that he will take him up into heaven to wait there until the end of the world. Enoch is then carried up into heaven (probably aboard the same cloud machine that earlier carried the Father into the highest heaven), where they continue their conversation (2095–2146). There are no such scenes in *Bewnans Ke* however because there is no heaven *tentum*, and neither God the Father, nor Jesus, nor angels ever make an appearance. There are plenty of devils, however, and Ke carries on quite a long evangelical debate with the tyrant, Teudar.

100. The text specifies that Jesus takes his Disciples to the Mount of Olives (*in montem olivarium*), where Gethsemane is located (sd at line 1010). He singles out Peter, John, and James the Greater to accompany him to Gethsemane, but apparently he leaves them just outside the Garden. He withdraws from them into the Garden and returns to them three times. Given the widespread figuring of Gethsemane as the New Eden, it is likely that the gated Garden of Eden that was located in the *platea* for the *Origo Mundi* during the previous day's performance is here reused as Gethsemane in the *Passio Christi*. Christ as the New Adam can enter Gethsemane, but neither the Disciples nor the Conspirators may. The same *locus* will probably also be refigured as the Garden of the Resurrection from the *Resurrexione* in the following day's performance. The stage diagram does not include these gardens, but the diagrams only indicate the positions of the *tenta* around the peripheries of the circular *plains-an-gwary*. The texts themselves, however, indicate quite a number of additional locations in the *platea*. These gardens may well be located at or near the centre of the *platea*, but as the stage directions make clear, the Conspirators have to get there by *ambulantes in platea* (walking in the *platea*), sd at line 1086.
101. These ironies are developed further by other events staged simultaneously. As the Tyrant is sending the Son to prison on one side of the *plain-an-gwary*, a messenger arrives to report his capture to his mother on the opposite side. The woman goes to the church in the centre of the *platea* to pray to the Virgin and (as the stage direction tells us) 'she kneels and waits in the same place' (sd at line 3590). While she waits and prays, the action shifts instantaneously to the Tyrant, who announces to the Jailor that the Son will be executed in the morning. Then it shifts back to the praying mother, who takes a figure of Jesus from the arms of a statue of the Virgin; she exchanges Mary's 'little son' for her own and leaves the oratory: 'I will not annoy thee | Here praying more' (3615–38). Eventually, Mary descends from heaven, frees the Son, and asks him to tell his mother to give back the statue, which she does to end the episode (3659–3710).
102. See, for instance, *REED: Dorset and Cornwall* 406–408; also 468 for a record of 'the players of Melbroke' who performed at Antony in 1548. These may have been Robin Hood performances. See also the list of 'enterlude' players travelling through Cornwall compiled by Evelyn S. Newlyn 'The Middle Cornish Interlude: Genre and Tradition' *Comparative Drama* 30 (1996) 266.
103. Brian O. Murdoch *Cornish Literature* (Cambridge: Brewer, 1993) 12.
104. Newlyn 'Middle Cornish Interlude' 268.
105. Stern *Rehearsal* 10.
106. Butterworth 'Book-Carriers' 25.
107. Palfrey and Stern *Shakespeare in Parts* 15–39; see also Graham A. Runnalls 'Towards a Typology of Medieval French Play Manuscripts' in *The Editor and*

- the Text* edited Philip E. Bennett and Graham A. Runnalls (Edinburgh UP, 1990) 93–113 for a list and descriptions of French manuscript actors' roles. This is reprinted in *Études sur les Mystères* (Paris: Champion, 1998) 375–7.
108. An alternative description, 'the Middle Cornish Charter Endorsement', as employed in *The Middle Cornish Charter Endorsement* edited Laurant Tooriens (Innsbrucker Beiträge Zur Sprachwissenschaft; Innsbruck: Institut für Sprachwissenschaft der Universität Innsbruck, 1991), is equally unhelpful in identifying the verse as belonging to an interlude.
 109. Newlyn *Middle Cornish Interlude* 269, 274. I would suggest that the 'completely baffling statement', *Cas o ganso re nofferen* ('He hated it, by the Mass') may be the cue line that precedes the matchmaker's lines. It begins the third of Newlyn's 'scenes' just after the bar that separates the three parts of the matchmaker's role.
 110. Neuss *Creacion* xxxvii–xlix, especially xl, xliii–iv. Neuss' italics.
 111. Murdoch 'Cornish Medieval Drama' 225.
 112. A stage direction in *Beunans Meriasek* establishes that actors certainly might play multiple parts in these plays: 'And John ergudyn aredy a horse bakke y' was y^e Justis w^t constantyn ffor to play y^e marchont' ('And John Ergudyn, who was the Justice with Constantine, must be ready on horseback to play the Merchant') *St Meriasek* 106–107. Ergudyn's line load was very light; in a previous scene, he gives only three short speeches of 8, 5, and 3 lines respectively, and his main job is to present a urinal to the doctor for inspection. In an intervening scene, he changes into a merchant's garb, and then, as the stage direction indicates, enters again on horseback. As the Merchant, he is forced off his horse by outlaws and speaks only one speech of 6 lines in protest. This light line-load would seem more easily memorised by the actor than prompted by an Ordinary. He may, however, have played other parts as well.
 113. Betcher 'Makers of Heaven' 116.
 114. See Kipling 'Régisseur' 29–31, 61–90.
 115. See Gordon Kipling 'Theatre as Subject and Object in Fouquet's *Martyrdom of St Apollonia*' *Medieval English Theatre* 19 (1997), 26–80, and also 'Fouquet, St Apollonia, and the Motives of the Miniaturists's Art: A Reply to Graham Runnalls' *Medieval English Theatre* 19 (1997) 101–120. That the performance looks as if it is taking place in a fifteenth-century French theatre should not surprise us; the painter habitually represents the Roman past in contemporary French costume and setting.
 116. Hulst, Zeeland, 1483: *men den bouchouwere niet bloot en ziet staen* ('that one cannot see the book-keeper standing openly'). Antwerp, 1496: *den boackhoudre bedeckt sijnde sal* ('the book-keeper will be covered'); Butterworth 'Groningen' 125.

117. Gosson's sneer occurs in his *Apologie of the Schoole of Abuse* (1579). Butterworth 'Carew's Ordinary' 329.
118. REED: *Kent* 1 231. There are two versions of this record. The one cited here and in Butterworth 'Groningen' 125, derives from an unknown source that was published in Nichols' *Progresses of Elizabeth*. The other (230) takes less care to identify Dudley's and Cecil's offices; instead of specifying that the two men 'vouchsafed to hold both books', it merely refers to 'bokes'. See also Stern *Rehearsal* 95–6 for an attempt to make sense of this record.
119. REED: *Kent* 1 227.
120. Perhaps the University had its own reasons for the gesture as well. A play about Queen Dido, after all, could not help to suggest parallels with Queen Elizabeth, and Cecil who demanded to confer with 'some man of knoledge', would have had to make enquires about the entertainment. It would not be the first time that an entertainment might offer advice to the Queen about securing the succession with a marriage. Perhaps, indeed, Cecil wanted the play to address this issue. He had only recently supported a Parliamentary petition that the Queen marry, and it would thus be useful to have the Queen's minister of state and the Queen's favourite on stage to find no difficulties in the play.
121. For original quotations and sources, see Butterworth 'Groningen' 128.
122. This reminiscence was published in 1884 and refers to events that occurred at least twenty years previously. See Butterworth 'Groningen' 128 for full text and 171 note 22 for source. See <http://www.vam.ac.uk/content/articles/t/the-story-of-music-halls/> for the convention of the music hall chairman, together with an illustration from the Borough Music Hall, c. 1859, that replicates the description of the Shropshire chairman.
123. Butterworth 'Groningen' 126–7. The emphasis on the shortness of the period between writing and production, however, may suggest this is a rehearsal technique aimed at rapid learning of lines before performance. On this point, see next section.
124. Butterworth 'Groningen' 127. The actress Salma Hayek reports having performed in a Mexican *telenovella* in this fashion.
125. Butterworth 'Prompting' 240–47, especially 242–3; see also Butterworth 'Book-Carriers' 15–30, and Butterworth 'Groningen' 122–71.
126. Butterworth 'Prompting' 242–3.
127. Butterworth 'Groningen' 146.
128. Butterworth 'Prompting' 245–6.

129. James Howell *A New Volume of Letters* (London, 1647), quoted in *OED* sv *Maggot*, n 2a. See also *brainworm* n 1. The word is obsolescent, not obsolete. See John Fowles *A Maggot* (London: Jonathan Cape, 1985) 5.
130. In rehearsing his own production of the *Secunda Pastorum* in the manner of Carew's Ordinary, Butterworth reports that scripts were passed out before rehearsals and that his actors were to read them and select two scenes to be performed: 'Groningen' 129–37 at 129.
131. In distinguishing between 'the kind of prompting delivered by the Ordinary' and 'more recent and current forms' of prompting, Butterworth concedes that 'this difference begs some further questions. Why did this changed function or mode exist? What was the "Ordinary-player" relationship required to do that was different from more recent practice?' Except to deny that such a prompting performance would have seemed somehow crude and unsophisticated to the audience, he does not provide an answer to this question: Butterworth 'Carew's Ordinary' 328–9.
132. See above, section 3, and Spriggs 'Where Cornish Was Spoken' 228–69 *passim*.
133. Bakere *Cornish Ordinalia* xxxvi.
134. REED: *York* 1 109. I am indebted to Pamela M. King for calling this record to my attention.
135. Butterworth 'Groningen' 129–36.
136. Butterworth insists (159) that although the actors became 'familiar' with the lines, they did not memorise them. I accept this assurance, even though I remain unclear as to the distinction between the two terms, since the actors did not have to 'pronounce aloud' what the prompter 'telleth them softly beforehand'. Rather, hearing one or two words, they could speak the rest of their lines from memory.
137. See above, note 122.
138. Stern *Rehearsal* 10–11. Stern takes rehearsals from the sixteenth through the eighteenth centuries as her topic; these practices, she thinks, remained fairly constant throughout these centuries, hence the reference to Garrick and Shakespeare in the same sentence.